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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sgLWk0Tr3nE
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:09:16] Are we up? Okay. Good morning. My name is Grace Creasy. I'm the president of the Virginia Board of Education. I'd like to call this meeting to order. At this time, the chair will entertain a motion for the board to go into executive session. The chair recognizes Mr. Hansen.

[00:09:34] I may with the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes, discussion or consideration by the Board of Education, information relating to the denial, suspension, or revocation of teacher licenses subjects to the exclusion and subdivision 11 of section 2.2-3705.2 pursuant to section 2.2-3711A40 of the code of Virginia and consultation with counsel regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant

[00:10:08] to Virginia code section 2.2-3711A8 of the code of Virginia and the legal counsel to the Virginia board of education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting is there a second motion has been made and seconded by mr. Hanson seconded by miss Northam all those in favor please say aye any opposed no okay the motion carries and the board is now an

[00:10:43] executive session all staff members of and members of the public who have not been authorized to participate in this executive session we need you to exit the room at this time please the

board will reconvene a public meeting

[00:10:56] immediately upon the conclusion of the executive session thank you okay we are

[02:08:38] back and the chair will entertain a motion to certify the purpose of the meeting in closed session the chair recognizes mr. Hanson we convene today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act section 2.2 - 3 7 1 2 of the code of Virginia requires that the board certify that the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were

[02:09:15] heard discussed or considered any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote indicating the substance of the departure and in his or her judgment has taken place the statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes there a second a motion has been made and seconded. This will be a roll call vote. All those in favor will indicate by saying aye.

[02:09:39] Ms. Kilgore, Dr. Northern, Ms. McPherson, Ms. Holton, Mr. Hansen. Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. Officially out of closed session and I would like to bring us into the work session.

[02:09:58] But before we start that, I just would like to make it aware, give the public a little bit of notice that today we're kind of jumping around on our agenda. We had to take some cases early this morning. We are coming out of closed session and beginning the work session in order to address a couple of our speakers who have come to grace us with their presence today in order to provide us their national expertise in a couple of different areas that the board is examining currently.

[02:10:31] And so we are thankful that they are here with us today. And our first presentation is standard setting definition of proficiency in scoring assessments. But what I would like to do is take a moment to remind the board and the public that we discussed this in August and again in December.

[02:10:52] That the board will be discussing the return of proficiency standard setting and ensuring our expectations are on top in the nation. Virginia believes that Virginia students deserve an excellent system of public education that prepares every Virginian for success.

[02:11:10] And to provide the best in-class education system that every student deserves, it requires an increase in rigor and accountability for all students. Under the prior administration, the board voted to lower the proficiency cut scores on the state assessment.

[02:11:26] and lowering those cut scores reduced the number of items that a student must respond to correctly to be categorized as demonstrating proficiency. This change caused the Virginia standards for reaching proficiency to be among the lowest in the nation for reading and mathematics.

[02:11:46] We will see here, as we discuss in the next couple of presentations, that the NAEP state mapping study demonstrates the reduction in rigor that occurred here in Virginia. Governor Yunkin announced that Virginia's lowest-in-the-nation mastery standards would be raised to align with the demands of the knowledge economy as part of our commitment to Virginians event in May of 22.

[02:12:13] Virginia mastery will be benchmarked against employer higher education knowledge and skill demands, proficiency and the highest state definitions across the nation. Governor Youngkin is committed to restoring excellence to education which includes more rigorous standards and the four core subjects

and greater transparency and accountability and a new assessment system. The evidence-based process requires standards to be raised first, assessment items to be aligned to content and rigor, and mastery setting based on the results of the new content and

[02:12:51] questions in the assessment. Governor Youngkin directed the board to raise Virginia's expectations to be the highest in the nation by aligning them with National Assessment of Educational Progress NAEP proficiency standard and that is our goal in launching this process today.

[02:13:07] After this presentation we will hear from additional national experts on these particular topics and what I would like to conclude with in these remarks is to say that today is the day for questions to be asked and answered and for public comments to be made on these items.

[02:13:27] Tomorrow is our business meeting and we will proceed with business in an efficient and effective manner and so I would ask that if you have questions concerns comments that they be aired and discussed today rather than spending hours on in tomorrow during a business meeting. So with that Ms. Cooper, please proceed. Madam President. Ms. Holton. Just before, if I may respond briefly to your opening remarks before we hear from Ms. Cooper. Briefly. I just want to note, just for

[02:14:04] the board's clarity, the Constitution gives this board the very explicit responsibility to make decisions about standards and standard setting, and we certainly welcome the governor's advice about aligning with nape proficiency and that's certainly an option that the board may choose to do but it is not the governor's decision it is our decision that would be my first point and number two unless i am missing something we have not yet made that decision we've talked about it a lot in

[02:14:38] a lot of different ways but i think that decision is before us on what's being presented on first review tomorrow and presumably final review at our next meeting so that is a decision point for us going forward, not a done deal. Thank you. Cooper. Good morning, President Creasy, Dr. Coons, and members of the board. Today I am presenting our proposed proficiency standard setting process to seek approval and input on key steps from the board. This ensures that we are responsive to the feedback from the field and community about a transparent process. It is important to note that

[02:15:16] previous iterations of the committee selection process have not been brought to the board in prior years. As President Creasy mentioned, Virginia has the lowest standards in the country in ELA and math. Two key actions occurred several years ago to focus on increasing rigor and accountability. The first one was in 2022. Governor Youngkin directed the board to raise Virginia's expectations for students from the lowest in the nation to the highest by aligning them with the NAEP proficiency standard as part of our commitment to Virginians, which you can see

[02:15:51] on our website. Two, House Bill 585 of the 2022 legislative session required a work group to assess the current state of Virginia's assessment system and to develop a plan for the future state of Virginia's assessment system. Two of the areas that the work group recommended were clearer and more rigorous standards and more rigorous assessment items. Over the past three years, this board has prioritized raising expectations for students through the adoption of more rigorous standards of learning and through the approval of the new school performance and support framework.

[02:16:29] VDOE has also redesigned summative assessments to more fully measure the rigor of the new academic content standards. Building on this foundation, the board must now set new assessment cut

scores on these summative assessments to align proficiency to the increasing demands of the workplace and benchmarked to ensure Virginia students perform best in the nation.

[02:16:51] I'd like to revisit the honesty gap in Virginia's student performance. For over a decade, the definitions of proficiency have been far lower on Virginia tests than that of the nation's report card. And Virginia has had the lowest definition of proficiency in the country for the past four years. As you can see, our state's SOL test scores tell a different story than what national proficiency scores tell us. What we have communicated to teachers, students, and families is not an accurate picture of student performance, and as of 2022,

[02:17:30] there was a 40 percentage point gap. Jim Cohen, who has been the national expert around the honesty gap, is here to chat more about this topic and answer questions after this presentation. Here, you can also notice the misalignment of Virginia standards to national standards.

[02:17:50] The National Assessment Governing Board approves the standard-setting process for NAEP, and a state mapping study was released comparing states' proficiency standards to NAEP proficiency standards. This study is another demonstration of the reduction in rigor that has occurred in Virginia.

[02:18:09] Our proficiency standards map to NAEP's two lowest categories that are not proficient, below BASIC and BASIC. This, in addition to Virginia students continuing to struggle on NAEP, as reported in last month's NAEP release, highlights why we must adjust our cut scores.

[02:18:28] The board must ensure that statewide definitions meet national expectations to ensure that Virginia students can effectively compete in a national and global workplace. We have brought Leslie Muldoon, Executive Director of NAGB, here today to share more details and address questions you may have as well.

[02:18:47] To achieve the best inclination expectations, the implementation timeline continues through this summer. The Board of Education will be highly involved in the decision making process, which includes methodology timelines and committee member process.

[02:19:05] As mentioned earlier, once new rigorous standards are approved and the assessments are aligned, the last step is to complete the proficiency standard setting process. The Board approved new standards and those assessments have been aligned.

[02:19:21] This fall, the TAC recommended that VDOE complete the standard setting process at the end of the spring assessment cycle so that the most current data from our students is used in this process. This timeline allows for the consideration of the 2024 NAEP data in establishing the updated proficiency standards.

[02:19:42] This month, the board will vote on the standard setting committee process as part of the board overseeing the process and making critical decisions around the setting of cut scores. This spring, students and teachers will receive score reports that use the current mastery levels that are already in place.

[02:20:01] In addition, the standard setting process will occur over multiple days at the end of our testing window. This process will allow the committee to use student performance data to understand how the standards and test items are providing rigor, how the cut scores should match NAEP performance and aligned to the knowledge and skills of Virginia's employers and admission standards to higher education.

The board will vote on the proposed cut scores recommended by the proficiency setting committees and the Technical Advisory Council in June and July.

[02:20:34] The updated performance standards will not be applied until spring 2026. This timeline allows the process to be completed prior to the next school year, which allows for transparency and preparation for the new year to educators and families and provides an opportunity for school divisions to receive training and resources on the new cut scores the standard setting review committee reviews data current performance levels and assessment item types to make recommendations on future content area cut scores for the board

[02:21:10] with the goal of sol cut scores being aligned to nape the national assessment governing board recommended that Virginia mirror the standard setting process that is implemented for NAEP. The proposed review committee process has four key phases. During phase one, committee selection, the department will hold a call for nominations once the board approves the process for selection.

[02:21:36] We recommend that this committee be comprised of 70% Virginia educator experts and 30% community members such as higher education experts workforce and industry leaders and other community stakeholders about 200 members would be selected over about 20 committees in phase two committee training it's recommended that all selected committee members go through several training steps to ensure that members are prepared to participate in the committee meetings

[02:22:10] in an exemplary way. Next in phase three committee convenings were proposing that the committees would review specific grade level and content specific data, the vertical band of performance levels, current performance data from grade level students, and assessment item types to make recommendation on cut scores. They would be responsible for recommending cut scores that not only reflect students achievement status but also promote the high expectations for all students in

[02:22:44] virginia and then in the final phase board and stakeholder feedback our plan is to have cut score recommendations presented to the board for first review and feedback in june proficiency cut scores would also be released for public comment and then video we would provide review that public comment in coordination with the technical advisory committee and proficiency cut score recommendations would be presented for final approval in July. This proficiency setting proposal will not only ensure that every student in the Commonwealth is held to high standards,

[02:23:20] but it will also address the honesty gap. We are so privileged to have Dr. Chris Domolesky here today. Dr. Domolesky serves on our TAC and is a nationally recognized expert in assessment and psychometrics. There is no one better in the country than for him to be here with us today.

[02:23:40] and as you can imagine, he is in high demand. So, Dr. Domolesky, we are so grateful for you being here and rearranging your schedule to speak with our board. He is going to share more details around the standard-setting process to obtain cut scores, so I will turn it over to Dr. Domolesky.

[02:24:01] Thank you very much. It's good to be with you again today. Thank you so much for being here. I know you had to do a considerable rearrangement, and we are so, so thankful to have you here. Thank you. My honor, thank you for the invitation, President Creasy, Superintendent Coons, members of the board, thank you for having me back.

[02:24:21] I'm glad to be here today, and I'll keep my remarks succinct because I do understand that we want to leave time for some interaction, and I'm happy to entertain questions and discussion at the

pleasure of the board. I think I was with you in August last, and at the time I had a chance to tell you a little bit about myself and the Center for Assessment.

[02:24:42] We're a non-profit, non-partisan organization. We work with the majority of the states to help provide advice on development, validation of assessments and accountability systems. And I'm also here in my role as a member of Virginia's Technical Advisory Committee.

[02:24:57] I did want to point out that the Technical Advisory Committee all reviewed the slides that I'm going to speak to today and have knowledge of the remarks that I'm going to share. Obviously, any limitations are mine alone. But I want to know my colleagues on the TAC, who I have great regard for, all contributed to this information and stand behind the message that I'll share with you today.

[02:25:17] And the TAC will continue to work with the department in refining the standard setting methodology and ensure that we follow established professional practices and the guidance of the board. Just a reminder, what is standard setting? It's the process by which we're determining cut scores for Virginia's state assessments.

[02:25:38] That's the shorthand that most people use, cut scores, or how those performance standards are operationalized. And many people might be surprised to know that that's not entirely a technical enterprise. It involves judgment from appropriately qualified experts and panelists, as the process that we're going to speak to today certainly does.

[02:25:59] And I think I emphasized this last time, but it's worth repeating, that there's no right answer. there's no truth of the capital T when it comes to what are the right performance expectations for any state assessment. We strongly believe that the credibility and the trustworthiness comes from implementing a strong process, implementing that with fidelity, and attending to best professional practices. And so that's what I'll emphasize in my remarks. I noted last time, and again, I'll amplify the point that the standard setting process is a necessary but

[02:26:35] insufficient overall condition to operationalize the desired rigor of the standards for the Commonwealth. It starts, and I heard Ms. Cooper mention this just now, so we're totally aligned, it starts with implementing strong content standards, very clear definitions for knowledge, skills, and abilities that students should know and be able to do in the state. The assessment needs to reflect those academic performance expectations so certainly we need items that run the full range of cognitive complexity and really probe the breadth

[02:27:11] and depth of the standards and substantial work has been done in order to ensure the test does that and it's reflected in the blueprints and the test in the test specifications and then of course and this is the reason for my being here today and for your consideration the policy priorities policy priorities absolutely inform where standards are set. It's really the combination of the content standards, the assessment, the standard setting process, and the policy priorities that go into determining what those performance expectations are. And I really appreciate, and I mean this with all candor, I really appreciate the level of scrutiny that this

[02:27:47] board is giving to those policy priorities. Sometimes that's an afterthought, and I really appreciate the board is really on the front foot and discussing very explicitly what those priorities are and how to make sure they're instantiated in the process. Performance level descriptors is a term that I'll use as we talk about standards. The performance level descriptors describe those knowledge, skills, and

abilities associated with each level below basic, basic, proficient, advanced. There are different types of performance level descriptors and I won't go

[02:28:25] into detail on all of them, but you see them listed here in the slide. It starts with policy definitions. These are usually statements from the education leaders in the state about the kinds of characteristics or benchmarks that should accompany those performance expectations. Often you see phrases like adequate to ensure that students are ready for post-secondary success or on track for post-secondary success. So they're very succinct statements of what the policy ambitions are.

[02:28:52] The more detailed at range and threshold PLDs. Range PLDs, as the name implies, should cover the full breadth. Obviously, there's some room, say, in the range of basic or proficient for students who are just at the threshold all the way to the kinds of knowledge, skills, and abilities that are associated with students that are right up against the next threshold.

[02:29:14] So the range PLDs try to describe that continuum of expertise and how that is demonstrated. Threshold PLDs very obviously describes that, in the case of, say, proficient, that just proficient student and really hones in on that borderline level of performance.

[02:29:35] And for some standard-setting methodologies, that's a particularly important PLD to develop. And then reporting PLDs is how most of the public interacts with the performance level descriptors. These are the statements that are usually about a paragraph or so long that accompany the ISRs or the individual student reports or other public statements about those performance.

[02:29:55] They're intended to be accessible so that a full range of constituencies can appreciate what's being described in those performance levels. So there are, oh my goodness, there are whole volumes, courses dedicated to standard setting methodology. There's no way that I could very briefly give a full account for all the kinds of approaches that are in use and the nuances associated with each. But I thought it might be useful for me to just pick three very commonly implemented standard setting methodologies and

[02:30:33] linger on each for just a moment. The modified Angoff, this was one that was used a lot more some years ago. It was one of the initial standard setting methods that gained in popularity. And what I've tried to do with each rather than cover everything is just really focus on what the central task for the panelist is. What are we asking of the panelist in a modified Angoff?

[02:30:57] In that methodology, the panelists are considering the probability that a student who is at that performance level, be it basic, proficient, advanced, can answer questions. So they go through each of those items and they try to make a probability statement.

[02:31:14] Sometimes it's modified so that instead of making a probability statement like, oh, the student has a 50% probability of answering the question correctly or a 75% probability, they would just answer that the affirmative or the negative, yes or no. And there are different modifications of Angoff. In fact, Angoff almost always is modified to some extent when we see it in practice. That is the legacy method, I understand, that was used in Virginia. So again, very common, has a strong research base. The bookmark method, this really started gaining more traction, I'd say, in the late 90s and the early aughts. And the essential question here, the panelists are looking at a list

[02:31:54] of ordered items, ordered by their difficulty, the probability that a student is going to respond to them correctly, and they're placing a marker in that ordered list that differentiates when a student is

more likely, a student at that next level would be more likely to respond affirmatively to those items. So you take those ordered item lists, you put those bookmarks, where you start to see the shift occur from, say, basic to proficient to advanced, and then there's some statistical connections between that item

[02:32:29] and how it gets translated into a scale score in order to determine where the cut scores are. That's probably a trail we don't need to follow too much, but it has to do with determining a response probability and then using item response theory to translate that to the scale score.

[02:32:48] With ID matching, it really has some flavors of each of the two, but the central question shifts a little bit for panelists. Now, panelists are matching items to specific performance levels in this method. So we're not so much considering would a borderline student answer this question correctly, or what would the probability of that student answering the question correctly.

[02:33:10] Now it's really more of a matching task. Now we're saying, let's look at what the demands are in the performance level, and let's look at what the knowledge and skills ability that the item is intended to elicit, and let's match up those items with the performance level in a way that makes sense. It still operates in an ordered item booklet, so we're still going through items in order of difficulty, and we're still looking for those transition points when we do that. But many have argued, and I'll make this point a little bit more on the next slide, that that is a much clearer task for panelists, that's much more cognitively clear. We know from research that for example the panelists just aren't really aren't good at all

[02:33:50] at predicting student probability on on items so this really just focuses on the content and they're matched to the items to the performance levels and it centralizes the demands of the academic content we've seen the ID matching grow quite a bit over the last 15 years or so there's a seminal publication I think in 2008 that really sparked the growth of the ID matching method and in my experience, most states are shifting to ID matching now. Not in any way suggesting it's popularity contest that Virginia should pick the one that's most popular, but there are some

[02:34:24] advantages in having a widely used method insofar as there are really good methods and we get lessons learned and systems in place that help us to implement that with fidelity when there are widespread practices. But again, I'm not ruling out that any of these methods are necessarily insufficient. I'll be quick here. I've already kind of named some of the pros and cons associated with these. I talked about the limitation with Angoff and how difficult it is for panelists to make judgments about item difficulty. With the

[02:34:58] bookmark, if it's less of an issue about the judgment task, we do bring in the importance of the ordered item booklet when you go to a bookmark method which of course carries over to ID matching so it requires that there's stable and trustworthy data available before the standard setting so you can have confidence in those item parameters both for the construction of that order item booklet and for the translation of that marker in the booklet to the scale score so it really matters that you have trustworthy

[02:35:35] information about that, and as Ms. Cooper mentioned in her remarks, being able to construct that after an operational or a full census administration gives us a lot more confidence in our ability to do that with integrity than, say, relying on a pilot or a field test for that purpose. So from a technical standpoint, it's very desirable that OIBs can be constructed based on good data. Whatever the method is selected. I believe these characteristics accompany any method that we're going to call

[02:36:09] defensible. We need well-qualified, well-trained panelists, and you heard some remarks earlier about how Virginia is moving forward to implement that. We want to centralize judgments on content-based expectations described in the performance level descriptors. We want to include efforts to promote coherence because obviously this is being done for every grade content intersection and you want an opportunity to look across grades for example to look for coherence and i think we'll have a

[02:36:43] chance to speak more about that in just a moment and um and with any standard setting method we want to ensure that the methods and the rationale are well documented they're reviewed by appropriate technical experts such as the state's technical advisory committee and policy leaders so always advocate for full transparency throughout the process. I think that adds to the credibility of what we're doing and how we're going about doing it. As I noted, the proposal is to transition from an Angoff-based method to ID matching method. In the past, Virginia's implemented

[02:37:22] the modified Angoff, and we support moving to ID matching, we being the Technical Advisory Committee, for again many of the reasons i think i've already enumerated it certainly matches up with those quality criteria that i mentioned strong research base the panelists task being very clear that was something that was particularly important to virginia's tack so that was something they elevated in the discussion so we think that that is a strong methodology to implement to establish

[02:37:55] those performance expectations a note just a bit more about the the process itself and I believe I also provided a one pager that covers some of this or may have had a chance to look that over I understand the the specifics of the process are still being developed part of which is contended on the guidance of the department in this board but the general procedures followed this arc Panelists will review the test and the PLDs. In multiple rounds, they'll evaluate this ordered

[02:38:29] item booklet and make those matches, matching those items to the performance levels based on the extent to which those knowledge, skills, and abilities are represented. And then after each round, they get an opportunity to see feedback across all participants and see kind of how their ratings matched with everybody else's ratings. And the whole idea is that the panelists can learn from one another if somebody is say more rigorous or less rigorous than their colleagues then they can learn what their perspectives were and they can take that into account as they

[02:39:04] complete the task in subsequent rounds and usually the process will provide more information information about impact and as i'm going to talk about in the present case information about correspondence with nape data after that's done then you get these candidate cuts that represent the places in that oib where the performance levels shift and you sort of see a visual representation of that in the bottom of the slide there you see the items are basic basic basic proficient proficient proficient so forth there's going to be sort of the zone where that transitions

[02:39:38] you find the median of that zone that gets translated to a scale score and then the final process before documentation and review from the policy leaders in the state is to do a vertical articulation which is to look across grades and content areas and determine if any adjustments are needed for the sake of coherence so a feature that is it's it's not um unheard of but it is less common is um in order to to make sure that we're aligning the policy priorities of this board and

[02:40:17] of the department into that process, we're proposing to bring NAEP data explicitly into standard setting. So the idea is to map the NAEP standards to the state tests and come up. So you see in this graph, I can see it much better over here. You can see in this graph, and these are remarks I know the

board has heard already, that there is a very different distribution of impact across those assessments when you look at the nape data this particular illustration shows i think it's eighth grade reading you see about a third of the students below basic see 37 percent in that

[02:40:53] basic range and you see the remainder of students at or above proficient looks very different over on the left with the virginia state assessment where you see only nine percent below basic 20 at basic and more than 70 percent at or above proficient so the idea here is uh to map nape to the state assessment. So we're really answering the question, what would be performance on the state assessment that would produce similar impact to NAEP? And then once you do that, it's a fairly straightforward statistical question to answer, then you can get these,

[02:41:31] we're going to call them reasonable ranges. We're going to get some zone around those plausible cut scores and be very transparent, very clear with the panelists that in that range we think are sort of it's an attractive area it's a plausible area to locate the cut score so you map it you provide those reasonable ranges and then you're just fully up front with the panelists and you say if you i think of it as kind of like shining a flashlight we're going to point the flashlight in this region of the oib we think that this is a promising area for you to focus

[02:42:05] and finding those transition points from performance levels and doing so will ensure some correspondence between the state assessments and the NAEP but at the same time and you can see the balance that we're trying to strike here at the same time you're not obviating the central task of keeping the academic content and the central question that the panelists are wrestling with at the center of the activity. We're just asking them to operate in a zone that is going to produce impact data that's relatively correspondent. Using reasonable ranges has been done with many

[02:42:42] other state programs in the past. Like I say, some states you do it, some don't, some do it with NAEP, some do it with maybe a legacy assessment or with some other impact data that's of high value. So this would not be, I'd say, I wouldn't say that it's common, but it is certainly not without precedent in my experience.

[02:43:04] And then I think this is my last slide here, the timeline. We're very pleased that the timeline allows for multiple reviews of the process and results, such as the review that we have here today, that the assessment data will be collected under operational conditions, which we think gives it more stability and credibility.

[02:43:22] I really appreciate the fact that Virginia is communicating those expectations in advance of the academic year in which they'll be implemented. That actually is not very common, so I really applaud Virginia for taking that stance. And so after all of that, the department will be able to document everything, submit it for federal peer review, submit it for all the different review channels that it will go through.

[02:43:49] So those are my prepared remarks. I'm happy to address any questions. - Okay. - Again, thank you so much for being here. - Of course. - We appreciate it, and I certainly appreciate the constant reminder of the process, having served on standard setting committees in the past, and understanding the complexity of the process, and also those cons to the current method that we use, certainly having been a part of those committees over the years.

[02:44:24] So. - Are there any questions? No, Dr. Northern, you said you had a few.

[02:44:46] Just in terms of the ID matching versus the bookmarking, I guess my main question is why can't the committee members do both? Because in my understanding, you've got this ordered booklet that presumably the TAC has done a job of thinking, okay, this is how we think they progress in order of level of difficulty.

[02:45:08] And then you've got the panel members saying, okay, I think this one's pegged to proficient, this one's pegged to below, and so on. But with the ID, I mean, with the bookmarking, you actually are asking them to say, okay, here's where I think the shift occurs from below basic to basic, for instance, in the booklet.

[02:45:25] Why is it that the committee members aren't asked to do both? Like, I understand there's an advantage of bookmarking and ID matching and that they both use the ordered booklet, which I'd love because I think that takes a lot of the pressure off of the committee members to do a lot of work. But is there a reason you talked about, you know, the probabilities are hard for the panelists and so on.

[02:45:46] But can you talk more clearly about why it is that it's better to have them identify at the item level to the PLD versus having them identify the shift that takes place in the ordered booklet? It's an excellent question. They are very close.

[02:46:02] And again, the real difference, and this really turns out to be one of the most important things about standard setting, is in the ask of the panelists. the central question that the panelist is sitting with and there's there is a very real difference in bookmark and id matching on that question in bookmark they're asked to think about a student we're giving them a threshold pld and we're saying think about that student who for example is just barely proficient now address whether or not that student is likely to get this item right or not and if the answer is yes then you mark it so if it's no you mark it so and then you look for for kind of where the yeses and nos start

[02:46:41] to transition across panelists. The central question we're asking in ID matching is we're not asking them to imagine a student. We're saying, look at the PLDs, look at what the item is supposed to elicit, and see if they match. And I would imagine you're gonna see some correlation between the task and bookmark and ID matching, but it's our judgment that the ID matching is gonna centralize the academic content and keep the pressure of having to make any kind of predictions about students off their shoulders, And we think that that is the preferred task of the panelists.

[02:47:16] But as you noted, Dr. Northern, the methodology from there forward is very coincidental. It's very similar. And so once you get those transition points in the OIB, the process of finding a cut score becomes very straightforward and very similar.

[02:47:32] - But is it my understanding that then you guys, the TAC, would then be, the responsibility then falls to you more to decide where those shifts occur in that itemized booklet after you've gotten the feedback from the panelists? - They really, once you get the feedback, the methodology is very similar.

[02:47:50] Usually you're looking at a sort of an uncertainty range 'cause it never lines up. You know, everybody's rating similarly and you get a very clear cut. You're always gonna get this sort of fuzzy zone and then you're gonna come up with some methodology like selecting the median from all of those ordered item booklet locations as the place and then translating it to a scale score.

[02:48:08] So once you get those judgments, the methodologies are very similar. Just out of experience, I would just say that, I guess, you have various, you have teachers who are serving on those panels that have

varying experiences, obviously, with different students from all across the state, you know.

[02:48:32] And so that's supposed to yield you that opportunity to say yes or no. And oftentimes, it's, I mean, we've spent hours in discussion on those things. And so, I don't know, I guess I just feel like the more objectivity available, the better.

[02:48:57] Dr. Coon, Madam President. Yeah, I appreciate that. I want to reiterate some of the things that Em mentioned earlier. One of the things that we're recommending that gets added in is an additional set of training so that there's dress rehearsal opportunities for the committee members to get very comfortable and have feedback loops.

[02:49:16] So we want to make sure, as President Creasy said, that there's opportunities for practice and recognition that this is a process. And we have built-in additional recommended times to make sure that all of our people coming across the Commonwealth to have this conversation have the opportunity to practice before they work through these scenarios.

[02:49:41] Thank you, Dr. Domolesky. We're really appreciative of your expertise and your help both with helping us understand but also serving on our TAC. Am I right? You've been involved with our TAC for many years or is that more recent advent? I believe I started in 2018.

[02:49:58] So I'm going back farther than that, but I'm sure you're familiar that Virginia's passing cut scores on the SOLs have been more closely aligned or corresponded more closely to NAEP BASIC or even below NAEP BASIC for going back really two decades.

[02:50:20] Am I right about that? You understand that? That's my recollection as well. Yeah. So this what the administration calls an opportunity gap is a long standing choice in Virginia that as as to how we were assessing what we wanted to do with our with our test scores, right or wrong. And now a recommendation is being made that we make a different choice.

[02:50:47] And you're here to help us with that. And I appreciate that. The difference is switching your first recommendation you have is switching from angoff to id matching and i just want to understand that process a little better um as i understand it the impact the first step of that is compiling these ordered item booklets and that is done by psychometricians staff the testing vendor some combination of them is that right the the doing the specific operational work is going to be the testing vendor staff and and and that is done based on what you described as a full census

[02:51:26] of administration of the tests is that right so they'll get item calibrations or difficulty estimates from the operational administration which is best case because it's census test of motivated students and they those would be used for the ordered item book and and i heard you say that that's better than doing it on field tests for instance so so help me understand i just am a little bit concerned about whether we've got a timing schedule here that's realistic so i'm we're the schedule we've been presented is would have the standard setting committees meeting in

[02:52:02] late may but many of our divisions some of our biggest divisions don't complete testing by then and am i right that the compilation of those ordered books takes a little bit of time so how How is that workable? - Yeah, and I'll say it's not immediately clear to me whether those operational calibrations come from the most recent event, or if they're, 'cause sometimes what we do, the operational calibrations come from prior events and they're carried over.

[02:52:27] So how those items, which event is being used to construct those OIBs, that's not a detail I have real deep insight into, but I can assure you Pearson has real visibility into the timeline and into the expectations. And so I'm not immediately worried that we're proceeding in some kind of reckless way there.

[02:52:47] So just to follow up on that a little bit, as you know, we have changed our content standards and have new test items that are being used this spring for the first time. And I heard you say that it's a good thing that we're trying to, I think we're expediting the schedule with the goal of having the divisions know what they're up against before the school year starts, but that that's uncommon. And in the past, we've always done, always typically done standard setting in the fall. So if you had to, if we need to delay it a little bit so that we can

[02:53:26] use the most recent test data, would that make more sense than trying to rush it through? Dr. Yeah, member Holton, what Dr. Domolesky said is, we are running it this year so that school divisions know what those proficiency scores will be.

[02:53:43] Those won't be operational in a year, so we want based on feedback in the field. The field has appreciated having a full year of knowledge, so we are being responsive to the field and the timeline and the request of the field, which Dr. Domolesky has worked with us closely on that.

[02:53:59] I have a number of questions for Dr. Domolesky because I really do benefit. I think we really benefit from your expertise, and I understand your schedule is short, so to the extent I can hear from Dr. Domolesky and hear from others later, I would just ask for that grace, given that I understand his schedule is tight.

[02:54:17] But so, at some point, we'll have to make a decision whether to proceed before we have the full results from this spring's test administration. we decided to push it a month later say uh for whatever reason and that means the uh school divisions don't know the final test scores until september maybe is that a problem or will that does that work based on your experience in other states yeah i'm not really sure how to respond i

[02:54:51] mean it is um like say it's the fact that um virginia is announcing them in advance at all is itself a feature. It's very common for states to say that we're going to wait until the administration then we're going to set standards and then sometime in the summer or fall we're going to sort of retroactively report how students did. That obviously has its own challenges so I think you're asking me to speculate on whether doing that sort of in the summer versus in the fall has some benefits or drawbacks and I'm not sure that I have a strong insight about it either

[02:55:26] seems preferable to me than doing it retroactively gotcha thank you okay so now once the once the ordered books have been put together the committees come together to review them those committees uh uh the proposal we've seen um is that 30 70 of those be teachers or educating educator experts and 30 be community members um that's new for us here in virginia to to have relatively new for us here in Virginia.

[02:55:55] Do you have any guidance or wisdom based on your experience in other states on what the criteria should be used for selecting those non-education expert members of the panels?

[02:56:11] - We certainly want them to be familiar with academic expectations. We want them to be familiar with the population of students that are assessed. We want them to be familiar with the impact

and use of assessment scores. want the panelists to be broadly representative of the different interests in the state. So all of that goes into account when selecting a panel. It's not uncommon to bring in outside community members into standard setting panels. I've seen panels have IHE representatives, institutions of higher ed. What is IHE? Institutions of higher education. It's not uncommon to have, I've seen

[02:56:49] panels with business leaders and advocates for different student groups, such as students with special needs or language learners. So mostly states will work to identify what interests are most prioritized to be represented, and they want to make sure that everybody's got good understanding of the policy priorities and of the academic content expectations in order to do the task. Because as I was discussing and reviewing that sort of central ask of the panelists, ultimately, whatever your background is, everybody's going to be doing the same thing. Everybody's going to be making judgments about the alignment of the PLDs to the academic

[02:57:25] standards. So having the expertise to fulfill that task becomes paramount. And I heard you say, so a cross-section, really, representative of various backgrounds, higher ed, business advocates, would you also want a geographic cross-section, parents, demographic cross-section? And I want to be careful not to misspeak. I'm not necessarily advocating for any of those groups. I was trying to be illustrative in describing what I've seen in other standard-setting events. What I would sort of go back to the process being really important, the process of education leaders here in Virginia working with their testing contractor to determine their priorities and making sure

[02:58:05] that they're represented. Geographic proximity is our geographic representation is almost always one of the factors that states look at. So I think that's a great example, man. And demographic representation as well. That's very often a priority as well. So now you've got your panels and they're looking at this ordered test and they're, I don't understand as well as my colleague, Dr. Northam, the difference between bookmark and ID matching, but I get the general idea that they're looking at questions, looking at the PLDs and essentially drawing some lines.

[02:58:37] Am I right that the NAEP piece, bringing the NAEP data in, is a separate step in the process? and that that would happen after the initial ID matching process has taken place?

[02:58:54] No, ma'am. It's woven into the process. And I don't know that we've gotten down to the operational details of how that will be done, but an example of that could be that maybe round one is an independent rating. Round two, they get the reasonable ranges. We could have that at round one, so they could operate right from the start with that, But it would be woven into the process, and in fact, it would be operationalized as guidance to the panelists as they work through the OIB.

[02:59:22] So we could just say, here's a lower bound and here's an upper bound. When I did this in another state years ago, nowadays everything's digital, but at that time it was a print OIB, and they just literally put like sticky notes, like this is the page where the lower bound starts, this is the page where the lower bound ends.

[02:59:41] Between these markers, we think is where you should focus your scrutiny because those are the sort of reasonable ranges for us to locate our standards. So it gets woven into the process. That's helpful to understand. And just so when you say reasonable ranges, basically the panel would be told, well, if you were trying to align with NAIC proficiency, you would want to draw the cut score between this and that mark, this and that percentage, essentially.

[03:00:13] and that there would be a range given for the difference between fail and pass and between pass and pass advance? All the panelists would see is they're going through the OIB and they say, here's where the lower bound starts. Now that's where the flashlight's shining.

[03:00:29] This is where I'm going to focus my scrutiny. And I'm going to do that as I go through it until I reach the upper bound. So it just becomes, it just literally emphasizes a zone in the OIB where they're operating. They don't really have to think about the impact of what they're doing and the percentages because, again, that's really not their purview.

[03:00:49] Their purview is making good decisions about aligning items to academic expectations. But they're going to be encouraged to aim for cut scores that are within those reasonable zones that have been determined by some combination of the TAC and the administration in giving them guidance.

[03:01:09] They're going to be invited to focus their scrutiny in those ranges. I think there's some confusion here and correct me if I'm wrong. They are looking at the question they are. These panelists are looking at the questions as to how difficult or how easy they are not assigning a cut score for the end of the process.

[03:01:34] So assigning what you're saying as they are doing the cut score work as assigning a total end. you know, whether they are pass, pass, advance or fail, that is not what's happening at that moment. They're deciding which questions fit into which category is correct. Okay, so thank you for thank you for thank you for that clarifying. But but regardless, they're being told at that later rounds anyway, if not the first round, they're being told that if you you're being invited and

[03:02:09] encouraged to align to the NAEP scores such that if these questions this many questions should be in this category versus this category if you want to align to the NAEP scores is that right there's no no desire to be anything but transparent with the panelists and would say these reasonable ranges were constructed for this reason and to satisfy this policy priority and so they They would know how they've been constructed.

[03:02:43] And again, I don't want to misspeak because we haven't gotten down to a fine-grained operational level in all this. And so I've seen when reasonable ranges are used in a standard setting, the kind of guidance that can accompany that changes or can be modified depending on the interests of the department.

[03:03:01] So one example of that could be, we invite you to focus your scrutiny in this range, but you can go out of the range if you can make a compelling rationale for that. In other cases, operating outside the range is more discouraged. So that level of detail, I don't think it's been worked out from this particular methodology yet.

[03:03:20] - So that's helpful and I'm almost done. I know there are others. But with that advice and invitation to align with NAEP scores, essentially we're working to ensure

[03:03:39] that the ultimate outcome is that our, our scores next, we'll know it, we'll know ahead of time that our scores the following year, they're going to align much more closely to the NAEP cut scores, because we have defined that into the process, we've built that into the process. So it won't be any surprise next year when our pass rates drop dramatically, because our current pass rates are built around NAEP basic. And now if this process goes forward, they're going to be around aligns around nape proficient and so you know pass scores barring students getting radically smarter over

[03:04:18] the course of one year our cut scores are going to drop from the 70 percentages down to the 40 percentiles am i right about that you're right that i would expect impact to be more correspondent with nape miss mcpherson so what i want to know is based upon the fact that we are switching and we're raising it so that we can have a more rigorous process what is the expectation of the length of time that the school systems and divisions will need for students to achieve

[03:04:54] the goal that we're looking for so obviously we're making it more rigorous we're going to implement the testing what has been historically the length of time that school systems have needed in order to see the improvement to get to the point where we are in line with the NAEP process i think that's a great question and i just want to be honest with you i just do not have an evidence-based way to answer that question um i don't know that i could fairly predict that

[03:05:30] dr kent is there a state or a couple of states that you can and you don't have to have the answer now that you can point out to us that move from a system similar to ours with scores similar to where we are that moved into the id matching that we could look at to see how long the performance took and maybe some of the operational things that were put in place to help the students in the school

[03:06:03] Dr. Gaines? I do want to mention, Chris said this before, but we are doing a whole year gap so that we have that transition time. That is not common among my peers in other states, is that we are giving per the ask of our school divisions that it is noticed in the fall and then they have a whole year before those new cut scores become operational. So we are spending that extra year as a response

[03:06:33] from our school divisions in their request dr northern um one just sort of factual question and one that's a little broader i think getting to miss mcpherson's question will we have released nape items to be able to put into the mix um as i understand the process we're we're not putting nape items in standard setting it's all um virginia state assessment items okay um and i guess miss - Ms. McPherson, I would just say to your question,

[03:07:11] Louisiana is one that's been held up across the country as a state that had just, and Ms. M. Cooper can discuss this if she'd like, but had very low literacy rates and instituted many of the changes that we're talking about here in Virginia, including recommending and making sure that the early elementary grades using high quality instructional materials is key all the things that we've done with with all in and the high intensity tutoring all these things um that states like uh louisiana and mississippi

[03:07:47] have done and if you looked at the recent nape louisiana is one of the few states that actually held pretty firm um and made made some some made some gains and mississippi's been held up for years and they were really low, kind of like we are now.

[03:08:04] And they made some pretty, pretty substantive changes to their accountability system and to their state policies and are seeing, in my opinion, the fruit of those labors. So I can only hope that we're gonna see similar changes as to Louisiana and Mississippi, given that we've taken a couple pages from their playbook.

[03:08:27] - Thank you. And I know Dr. Domolesky has another presentation he has to do at this time so we wanted to just thank you so much for um coming today uh for the time that you have given us we are always grateful uh for your presence here and your continued advice and counsel so thank you thank you president creasy thank you members of the board thank you um we do need to take a five minute break given the technology um piece here to switch to the next

[03:08:57] presentation. So quick five minute break. Thank you. Okay, thank you, ladies and gentlemen, we

[03:24:04] are back. And we are on to item B in our national presentation series. This is, it's actually my hope here that some of the questions that are raised about proficiency in our cut scores can be discussed and answered by the two experts who are following here. And so I would like to begin just by saying i'll go ahead and do all of my introductions jim if you want to come out too jim cowan is the executive director of the collaborative for student success a non-profit

[03:24:39] advocacy organization defending policies strategies and initiatives that accelerate learning and improve curriculum choices so that all kids are better prepared for college or career jim is a proud formal naval naval former naval officer and toned his communications and public relations experience as senior vice president at Ogilvy Public Relations Worldwide. He is a graduate of Marquette University and holds a master's degree in public policy from Georgetown University.

[03:25:10] He lives in the Commonwealth in Alexandria with his wife and two daughters. Our other presenter here today is Leslie Muldoon. Since 2019, Leslie has served as the executive director of the National Assessment Governing Board, an independent nonpartisan board created by Congress to set policy for the nation's report card, NAEP. As executive director she leads, implementation of the Governing Board's strategic policy priorities manages its staff of 12 and oversees an annual budget of $7.8 million. Leslie joined the Governing Board with the charge to enhance NAEP's

[03:25:49] value to the nation as a catalyst for action by policymakers and practitioners to improve student learning and to innovate NAEP and maintain its relevance in a changing education landscape. During her tenure, the governing board achieved bipartisan consensus on the first major updates in more than a decade to the NAEP reading, mathematics, and science assessments, launched a new strategic vision to chart the future of NAEP in an era of rapidly changing technology and societal change as well, and released four iterations of the nation's report

[03:26:24] card in 2022 and 2023, which served as the nation's most authoritative and widely covered study on the impacts of the pandemic on student academic progress. Muldoon graduated with a Bachelor of Arts in English and History from the University of Maryland and a Master of Public Policy from Georgetown University. She is a New Jersey native and the proud parent of three elementary school students in the dc public schools and also a former swimmer thank you all for being here today as we heard from m earlier we've lowered our proficiency expectations in

[03:27:02] reporting student performance and this has created an honesty gap here in virginia so leslie you've worked on nagby and we see the dramatic decline of the many states and their performance i am happy to turn over the presentation to you thank you so much and good afternoon i'm honored to be here and appreciate the opportunity to meet with all of you um okay but now my slides have disappeared hold on there we go um so as as you said i'm the executive director of the national assessment governing board the board was created by congress as an independent non-partisan entity

[03:27:42] to oversee and set policy for the nation's report card and it is comprised of state and and local education officials, teachers, principals, testing and curriculum experts, and representatives of the general public, including parents and business leaders.

[03:27:58] So I'm here and really pleased to be here to share some of what we know about Virginia's educational trajectory relative to the nation over the 35 years in which the nation's report card has been producing data for all 50 states.

[03:28:13] So before I dive into the data, I just want to make sure to share some important background information about the national assessment for those who may not be familiar. The Nation's Report Card, or NAEP, is the only nationally representative assessment of student learning in K-12 education. It assesses fourth and eighth grade reading and mathematics for the nation for 53 states and jurisdictions, as well as 25 large urban school districts every two years.

[03:28:40] And it allows us to understand how school systems are serving students across states and over time. We also provide national level results in other subjects such as science, U.S. history, and civics, which is really critical because we know those content areas are also crucial to students' mastery of core academic knowledge.

[03:29:00] NAEP is considered the gold standard in assessment with trend lines going back decades, which allows us to see how our U.S. students today are doing relative to their peers over time and how different groups of students are making progress over time. As you know, NAEP has been used and can be used as a catalyst for change.

[03:29:22] It is intended to help shine a light on how students are performing and allow state and local leaders to use that information to inform policy decisions, thus today's conversation. I know there's a lot of discussion in Virginia and nationally around what does it mean to be NAEP proficient, and so I'd like to share some examples before I dive into results.

[03:29:46] Do we have these slides in our book? I'm not finding them. I'm looking for them right now. Do we have them somewhere? I get them. I can see them there, but not that well. We do not have them. Okay. I'd be happy to make sure that, can you forward them or do you want, would you like me to forward them?

[03:30:05] Okay. Wonderful. Thank you. Thank you. These are just some examples of what it means to be at each of the NAEP achievement levels. So this is mathematics, and then I'll talk about reading.

[03:30:21] These expectations are anchored in the knowledge and skills that we know students need, as determined by panels of experts and practitioners. The NAEP achievement levels, I think it's important to note, date back to the early 1990s, when the NAEP program, when the National Assessment Governing Board was first established, and when NAEP first began assessing and reporting data at the state level.

[03:30:45] Until that time, it had been only really a national assessment. And the goal at the time was to make sure that we were reporting results, not only as arbitrary numbers on a scale, but anchored in what students should know and be able to do to be successful in their futures.

[03:31:00] And so the governing board establishes these levels. They have remained very consistent over time, which is a very important feature of NAEP. As state assessments change regularly across the country, NAEP is a sort of more of a constant to allow you to benchmark your progress relative to other states.

[03:31:17] So, it is, as you know, NAEP proficient and state proficiency are not always the same. NAEP proficient means that students have shown competency over challenging material, including subject matter knowledge and the ability to apply that knowledge.

[03:31:35] So, this slide has some examples for both fourth and eighth grade mathematics of what a student performing at the NAEP basic level might be expected to demonstrate relative to NAEP Proficient and relative to NAEP Advanced. So here in fourth grade mathematics, students at NAEP Proficient should be able to add and subtract multi-digit whole numbers, fractions, and decimals in both single and multi-step problems.

[03:32:01] The NAEP basic example is you can see a simpler item. This is having, we expect students at this level to be able to demonstrate that they can locate numbers on a number line. In eighth grade mathematics, you'll see students at NAEP Proficient should be able to apply the Pythagorean theorem to solve equations, whereas students at NAEP Advanced, which is a really more advanced and more rigorous level, we would expect them to be able to look at that figure and sort of restructure it and apply their knowledge

[03:32:36] of formula for finding the area of a figure to identify or to calculate the size of that blue figure there. So you can see sort of the progression and the scaffolding of the complexity of student knowledge and skill in these examples.

[03:32:56] So now I wanted to show you, I'll do one slide for fourth grade reading and one slide for fourth grade, excuse me, eighth grade reading. So here, and these are actual items from the NAEP assessment. So I can tell you how students perform, how many students got this item correct in Virginia relative to the nation.

[03:33:14] So this is an example based on the text, The Tale of Despereaux by Kate DiCamillo. At the NAEP basic level, we'd expect students to be able to recognize the reason for a character's action. And in 2024, 70% of public students nationally answered the question correctly.

[03:33:30] In Virginia, 75% did. At the NAEP proficient level, we'd expect a fourth grader to recognize an inference about a main idea and a story. So rather than just locating something, this is more about interpretation and comprehension. In 2024, 54% of public students nationally answered this correctly, and 55% in Virginia.

[03:33:51] So that's not a statistically significant difference, just approximately the same. At the NAEP advanced level, we would expect a fourth grader to be able to select text from the story that supports an idea about a character's feelings. And here, 22% of public students nationwide answered it correctly, and in Virginia, 25% did.

[03:34:12] Let's go to eighth grade reading. So this was an item where there were two passages, so eighth grade students, we would expect them to be able to read two different reading passages and be able to answer questions about them. And in this case, students scoring at the NAEP basic level in eighth grade, we would expect them to be able to identify the main character's motive correctly.

[03:34:35] 65% of eighth graders nationally answered this correctly, and 69% of Virginia students did. For NAEP proficient, we would expect that students would be able to answer a question about how the main character's statement applies to another character, and to be able to fully explain themselves here.

[03:34:53] So 28% of Virginia students answered that correctly, and 32% of students nationally did. And then finally, for NAEP Advanced, this is a question asking students to provide their opinion on the effectiveness of comparisons in the poem, and it is possible to answer the question in either direction, And as long as a student justifies their argument well, they would get full credit.

[03:35:18] 9% of students answered this question correctly nationally and 8% in Virginia. So you can see that there is, you know, overall in those examples, the scaffolding is sort of the first point I want to make. The level of complexity increases. And the second point is that Virginia students scored about, answered those items correctly at about the same rate as students nationally.

[03:35:40] So, you know, state standards, as you know well, vary. And that is by design and by intention. That is Congress's goal, right? With each state having its own state assessment system. But NAEP allows us to compare the relative rigor of states where states have set their proficiency bar.

[03:35:59] So this chart, I realize it's a little bit hard to read, but it is available in a report that we, hopefully you have, but if not, we'll make sure that you have a link to it. And here, my colleagues at the National Center for Education Statistics, which is the federal education statistics body, conduct a study every two years following the NAEP assessment administration to basically put states' proficiency levels on their own assessments onto the same scale as the NAEP assessment, so that we can compare in each of the four grades and subjects that NAEP assesses where states fall relative to each other.

[03:36:38] This is not about state performance on NAEP, this is about the rigor of the performance standards. And this first slide here is fourth-grade mathematics. So you can see that Virginia's proficiency level in fourth-grade mathematics is set within the range of NAEP basic.

[03:36:54] And that is true of many states, right? Most states are falling in this range between NAEP basic and NAEP proficient in fourth-grade mathematics. Virginia is also, however, the lowest on this scale for fourth-grade mathematics. Puerto Rico is far lower, down on the very far left of the screen, well below NAEP basic and then Virginia is the second lowest.

[03:37:18] There are states that have established their cut scores at or above the NAEP proficient level and you can see them on the right side of the screen. Illinois, Maryland, Alaska, Colorado, North Dakota, DC and Rhode Island are just above that mark. And I will show you this for fourth grade math, fourth grade reading and eighth grade reading.

[03:37:38] Because of Virginia's end of course exams in eighth grade, end of course exams in mathematics, we can't compare eighth grade NAEP cut scores to the eighth grade Virginia end of course exam. So this is the slide for reading. And here you'll see that Virginia's cut score for the state assessments in fourth grade reading maps to below the NAEP basic level.

[03:38:03] And here we see that Virginia is the lowest in the nation in terms of where it sets its cut score. And again, on the right side of the screen, And you can see that Massachusetts, Rhode Island, and Oklahoma had set their cut scores at above the NAEP proficient level.

[03:38:21] And the remainder of the states are falling sort of in the middle there with the exception of Iowa, which is also below the NAEP basic level. And here we are on eighth grade reading. And again here, Virginia's standard for proficiency is below the NAEP basic level and joined again by Iowa as the only other state in that range with Kansas, Illinois, Rhode Island, and Tennessee set their cut scores above the NAEP proficient level. So with that context on the proficiency standards, I want to now turn to data and actual data on student performance. And I'm going to start

[03:39:01] by looking at average scores for students in Virginia relative to average scores for students nationally. And then I want to break that down for you so you can look at your high-performing students versus your low-performing students. This is a very important trend that we've seen NAEP over the last

decade and one that we strongly encourage states to investigate as well. So this is student performance over time, going all the way back to 1992. We did do a couple of state assessments, one in '92, one in 2000, and then regularly every two years starting in 2003. So

[03:39:38] back in 1992, Virginia was scoring just above the national average in fourth grade mathematics. We saw tremendous growth for both the nation and Virginia over the next several decades, and then started to see a bit of stagnation nationally at about 2015. We see here that Virginia's trend line started to grow. The gap between the nation and Virginia grew, so Virginia was outperforming the national public school average in fourth grade mathematics for much of that time period

[03:40:10] from 2003 to 2017 excuse me 2019 and then we see a significant decline for Virginia students such that today Virginia students are performing at the same level as the national average rather than having this advantage over pure states so that's the average score and then I want to show trends for students who are at the higher and lower performing ends we define higher performing as as the 75th percentile on NAEP, and we define lower performing as the 25th percentile on NAEP.

[03:40:46] So here again, you'll see different rates of change and different directions of change for higher performing and lower performing students. We see a steeper decline for lower performing students in the last several years than we do for higher performing students, and that is true nationally and in Virginia.

[03:41:06] And again, we see the gap between the national public average and the Virginia average has shrunk. So that students both at the high and the lower end of the distribution are scoring at the same place in Virginia as nationally. Okay, I'm gonna try to move a little bit faster 'cause I wanted to provide a little bit of context on how to read those slides.

[03:41:25] So now this is eighth grade mathematics and you're gonna see a very similar story here to fourth grade. Although I would say that Virginia still maintains an advantage over the nation in terms of eighth grade mathematics scores. But similar to mathematics, we saw really significant steady increases over several decades.

[03:41:47] And then some stagnation in the middle of the last decade, from 2013 to 2017, a little bit of a bump, and then a steady decline since 2017. And that is true both nationally and in Virginia. For your higher performing, lower performing trends, we see an even starker decline here for lower performing students than we did in fourth grade mathematics.

[03:42:10] and this is a national trend that we're seeing it's a national pattern that's deeply concerning right our lower performing students have been losing ground for the last decade and it is uh predates the pandemic uh substantially reading um so this is uh fourth grade reading the national story in fourth grade reading is one of sort of steady or small but steady increases for a time and uh and then stagnation for at least a decade virginia's story is uh was a little bit better for a time you were making steady gains had a significant advantage over the nation and then

[03:42:48] we start to see declines in about 2017 in student performance and at this point Virginia's advantage relative to the nation has has erased and students are scoring at the same average level as students nationally and again as in eighth grade mathematics this is largely driven by those students at the lower the lower performing students in the 25th percentile and below all right eighth grade reading my final final one at looking at the data in this way eighth grade reading is nationally has been a

[03:43:21] real concern since about the 2015 to 2017 range we've seen steady declines overall and we see the same in Virginia and again as I've mentioned in the other subjects we see that Virginia's advantage has has eroded and and been erased and again driven by lower performing students overall. Our higher performing students are showing some declines, but not nearly as steep as for lower performing children. And if you think back to the examples I shared about what it means to be scoring at the NAEP proficient versus the NAEP basic level, you know, we're seeing the lower

[03:43:59] performing kids are well into the below the NAEP basic performance level. So they are really struggling with some of those foundational knowledge and skills in reading comprehension. all right so now i want to look at the data in terms of performance levels um and here you will see that um i'm so sorry yes this is the right side okay fourth grade mathematics so now we're looking the green bars are the percentage of students scoring at or above nape basic and the blue bars are students scoring at or above nape proficient and we're comparing

[03:44:36] the darker bar is virginia and the lighter bar is the nation so you can compare virginia to the national trend and again you are seeing that we have fewer students performing at or above nape basic or at or above nape proficient than in the middle of the last decade the pandemic certainly contributed to this but some of these declines were starting prior to covid am i right that the decline started pre-pandemic on reading but not math um the declines in in scale scores started

[03:45:15] before the pandemic as well so this is um let me go back to mathematics reading yes but math in mathematics it looks i want to make sure i'm looking at this from the right direction so 2017 is the high point here on for virginia in eighth grade mathematics on nape um in nationally it looks like the high point was 2013. so slightly different trend but still pre-pandemic and then this is fourth grade mathematics 2019 okay sorry yeah so 2017 is the high point in both

[03:45:57] no i'm sorry 2017 is the high point for virginia and 2013 is a high point for the nation meaning the drop started at 2019 no i mean well meaning that the drop was after the 2017 administration so it could have been 18 we just didn't assess let me find my slide here okay um so now again we're looking at this in terms of the percentage reaching those different thresholds the different performance levels um now i want to look at eighth grade mathematics and we see that you know as of

[03:46:36] last year 29 of virginia eighth graders were scoring at the nape proficient level which is just above the national average um or the national level excuse me i should say and in um we have 63 percent of students scoring at or above the nape basic level and here you'll see that sort of plateau in from 2013 to about 2017 to 2019 there's a there's starts to be a slight decline in 2019 with the number of students who are reaching that threshold of NAEP basic all right i think the picture is starker in reading than it is in mathematics you see that decline starting earlier

[03:47:15] um for virginia students uh reaching the NAEP basic level versus the NAEP proficient level starts to decline in 2017. and then here in eighth grade reading, again, we start to see these declines. There's stagnation of the percentage of students who are reaching those thresholds, and then the declines start to turn down in 2017.

[03:47:40] Okay, I'm almost done with data. Hopefully you love data because I love data. So now we introduced something new on the nation's report card this year, and we think it's a really important shift. It's slightly subtle, but we know, you know, as more and more students have been eligible for free and reduced lunch through the community eligibility standards.

[03:48:02] Our ability to report NAPE results by students' economic disadvantage, it's gotten a little less nuanced because so many more students could fall into the category of economically disadvantaged. So we have created a new socioeconomic status index measure that takes into account other factors besides students' family income. It includes their parental education, books in the home, the community's economic disadvantage, and then the students' eligibility for school free

[03:48:36] and reduced lunch. And I think the main thing I want you to take away from this is that both in Virginia and nationally, our students of higher socioeconomic status are clearing the bar of proficient and students who are in the middle and lower socioeconomic categories are you know failing to achieve that standard and you see this sort of as you would unfortunately expect an association between students socioeconomic status and their achievement level so that is I think something that you miss if you're just looking at their their economic disadvantage so this is a little

[03:49:16] bit more sophisticated a little bit more insightful and hopefully hopefully a better way to communicate about the relationship between students school and background experiences and how that contributes to their achievement I want to show the same so this was fourth grade math this is fourth grade reading and here we see a slightly different picture right high SES students are just at the NAEP proficient level or just below whereas students who are low SES or middle SES are barely getting to the NAEP basic level so reading seems to be

[03:49:54] a higher a little bit of a larger challenge for students to get to and we see similar patterns for Virginia and the nation although it does look like there's a bit of a difference between students at the middle and lower SES levels in Virginia relative to their peers nationally and then I just want to talk about who these lower performing students are. We get this question a lot, and I think it's really important to understand that students who are scoring below the 25th percentile on NAEP in Virginia and in the nation are a very diverse group of students. They come from all racial and

[03:50:32] ethnic backgrounds. They have parents who went to college, many of them. To be sure, students from traditionally marginalized communities, students from under-resourced communities are over-represented in that 25th percentile of achievers, but they are not, they are not homogeneous, right?

[03:50:53] There is a lot of racial and ethnic diversity in terms of their socioeconomic status. So I have some numbers that I want to attach to these. You can see here in fourth grade mathematics that students in this group below the 25th 68% are economically disadvantaged and 32% are not.

[03:51:15] 31% are identified as students with disabilities, 69% are not. 35% are English learners, 65% are not. 49% are from the middle socioeconomic category and 37% are in the low.

[03:51:31] And among racial and ethnic groups, we see 35% are black students, 32% are Hispanic and 24% are white. So hopefully that gives you a little bit of a flavor of just the heterogeneity here.

[03:51:46] In eighth grade, this is eighth grade reading, and I show this just to show you that it is largely a similar picture, regardless of the subject in grade. In eighth grade, we do get information from students about the level of education their parents attained. We do not ask fourth graders that because they can't tell us reliably, but eighth graders typically can.

[03:52:05] And here on the bottom right is the pie chart for education level. And I wanna just highlight that 5% did not graduate, their parents did not graduate high school, 21% had high school graduates as parents, 39% had parents who did graduate from college.

[03:52:24] So this is a population of students who have a lot of diversity in terms of their background characteristics. Okay, finally, a couple things to keep in mind. NAEP has no stakes for schools or students, but the critical information it provides does help you get more context about how students are doing in your state relative to others.

[03:52:48] And we are glad that states like Virginia are using this data to spark important conversations and to take those lessons and figure out what does it mean in the context of your own education system. I wanna highlight very, very briefly some research that shows that NAEP is not, the NAEP scores do matter, right?

[03:53:09] Assessment scores are associated with students' outcomes in life. There's research from Stanford, Eric Hanushek at Stanford, who estimates that decreases in NAEP scores equate to lower lifetime earnings for individuals and lower GDP for states because it affects the skill level of the workforce.

[03:53:27] So he has estimated that the losses we saw in eighth grade mathematics during the pandemic equate to about 31 trillion in future losses to the nation. Tom Kane at Harvard and Doug Stager at Dartmouth have shown that rising achievement on eighth grade NAEP is associated with higher incomes.

[03:53:44] and better educational attainment, as well as lower rates of incarceration and teen pregnancy. So these are not necessarily like high NAEP scores cause you to have a better life, but higher test scores are certainly associated with better outcomes economically and for individuals.

[03:54:01] And I would be remiss if I did not share that more is coming from the nation's report card. These are national assessment results, but we think they are really important to add to the picture of how our students are doing. This summer, we will be releasing the nation's report card for 12th grade math and reading. This is the first look at our students at the end of their k12 experience since the pandemic from the nation's report card. And in the fall, we will have eighth grade science scores, which we know, you know, science and is so critical for students, educational futures as well. And we want to make sure that we're adding to that picture.

[03:54:36] Students this time next year in 2026, we'll be taking the next nation's report card in reading mathematics and by the end of the 2026 calendar year we will have updated data so you can see where virginia students are scoring in about a year and a half thank you so much for the opportunity to be with you today and i will hand it over to jim thank you so much jim welcome thank

[03:55:11] you all um this is why leslie should go first um my name is jim cowan i'm the executive director for the collaborative for student success i appreciate the opportunity to be here today i have my my colleague Adam Ezring here today to keep me honest and be ready at spreadsheets if questions come up so we can we can handle those for you for a little over ten years now my organization has been focused primarily on holding students to high expectations to helping students educators meet that bar and following a strong system of measurement to make the adjustments that need to be done a very

[03:55:48] simplistic way to put it but in essence we are we are a communications organization and that is the way we have functioned. I'm going to talk to you about something called the honesty gap that has taken a little bit of root and has become kind of a coined phrase that we're happy that it's there. We'd like to talk a little bit more about it nationally and how it looks in Virginia for you today. First off, like I said, the honesty gap is a communications exercise. We're not trying to make this sound like it's more than what it is. This is not a highly analytical tool. This is a look at a simple principle, which is parents deserve the

[03:56:27] truth. And so we have worked closely with Wesley and the team at NAEP, because we do believe that NAEP is a strong bar and a strong system of measuring progress across the country. So the idea of the honesty gap is based on kind of a line of parity, if you will, where we have how states declare proficiency compared to how NAEP is showing proficiency. Of course, we would hope that states would be as proficient or even more proficient than NAEP. Unfortunately, a lot of

[03:57:05] times it's lower than NAEP for different reasons. So let's take a look at the first rollout we did on the honesty gap. The first honesty gap rolled out in 2015. It was based on 2013 data from achieve at the time. What we saw were that there were 14 states that had gaps between NAEP proficiency and state proficiency that were 40 points or higher. Virginia was not one of these

[03:57:39] groups. They had the honesty gap of 27 points, minus 27 points. So they were not perfect, but they were not in the worst performers. This is in fourth grade reading. In eighth grade math in 2013, Again, we had 12 states that had gaps that were 35 points or larger that came out. Virginia, also not in this group. They had an honesty gap of 29 points. Again, not the best, but definitely

[03:58:11] not in the worst group that we saw. So let's leap forward to 2024, our most recent honesty gap. We now, we said initially that we had 14 states with gaps that were 40 points or higher. In 2024, we only had two states that had 40 points or higher and it was iowa and virginia virginia had an honesty gap minus 42 points this is in back in reading and in eighth grade math initially we said we had 12 states with the biggest gaps of 35 points or more and in the most current one we had

[03:58:49] three states that had 30 points or higher and it was iowa missouri and virginia with with minus 34. so we started looking at what what what happened in this time frame to move us to this to this point and i think we can say a lot happened um there was a pandemic schools shuttered kids went home kids learned remotely um kids came back we started to see drops on nape scores we started to see drops on state summative tests we saw drops on formative tests we saw grades coming home from

[03:59:29] school, including from my own two daughters, that were A's. And I'm very happy that you had our friends from Learning Heroes in here not too long ago to testify, because what they showed was pretty startling, which is that 8 in 10 parents, I think they're kids on grade level, but only 4 in 10 are actually proficient based on NAVE scores. That's important to us, and it's something that personally I feel, and if you have kids, you feel that as well. So we recognize that, and what that has

[04:00:01] create is this difficulty in staying true to the honesty gap. It has created a level of opportunity to lower cut scores, to make yourself masked differences, and make yourself look more proficient than you actually are. It's becoming harder and harder to hold that higher bar. A couple weeks ago, I put out a piece in Forbes that looked at Virginia in particular, because I was curious, like, how did Virginia get next to Iowa on this? And so I began to look at what was going on in

[04:00:35] Virginia. I see that things happened in 2019. I see that there were changes in accreditation for schools. I see that there were lowering of cut scores before the pandemic. Then the pandemic hit, and it was literally a one, two, three punch on the state of Virginia, which caused, I believe, the state to drop to where it is today. I also noticed that you're not running from it, and that was the whole theme of the article, and I thought that that is an example for the rest of the country, I think, to follow, that the only way that you're going to deal with this is not shy

[04:01:13] away from it. And what I saw was very public and open acknowledgement of the issue. A lot of movement around accountability movements, working towards chronic absenteeism, dealing with a lot of the problems that we know can make a difference. And so the point of my article was to applaud that.

[04:01:34] Now again, this is a communications exercise. Our job is to take the extremely sophisticated work that is done at NAEP with those slides and turn it into something that average parents can understand, and I think they understand this.

[04:01:51] You don't run from a problem, you deal with it. And I think that's what Virginia is doing, and so that was what my intention was here today. That was much easier than what Leslie went through. I'll stop there.

[04:02:08] Are there questions, comments, questions? - Ms. Ma'am. - Ms. Holtan. - Thank you both for your presentations. Very, very useful. I know you both have a lot on your plates right now, especially where we're thinking of our friends in your world, Ms. Mildoon, and we're very grateful that you're making time to be with us today.

[04:02:33] Very helpful. Mr. An honesty gap question, and then I have a question for Ms. Mildoon.

[04:02:41] honesty gap question as as you've labeled it. I hear you that it's really primarily a communications tool and I appreciate that. I think I am right that Virginia I see you show that Virginia was not as bad by your honesty gap metric in 2013 and as it is as you would characterize it being now. But we've been we've been aligned. Our cut scores have been aligned much closer to NAEP basic than to NAEP proficient for decades. Am I right about that? My understanding is correct. So they were aligned there even in the

[04:03:20] years when we were doing high, when we were having high performance outcomes on NAEP and on our state SOL. So honesty gap issue that you raise is primarily about communications. It is a simple differential between what NAEP shows as proficient and what a state declares as proficient and above.

[04:03:47] And the changes that were made in 2019 were really fairly modest. The long-standing Virginia choice to align our cut scores, our pass rates to NAEP basic is what's responsible for what you characterize as the primarily responsible for what you characterize as the honesty gap.

[04:04:09] we we haven't done like a differential analysis to determine the exact cause of why they dropped but we're looking at things that would suggest reasons why they they would fall and so when at least when putting this other article together i i did look at like what what actions were taken yeah and the changes i'll tell you because i was here part of it the changes in 2019 were very minor so i posit that there's other things going on in terms of student performance and as we all know what really matters for student performance is teacher quality curriculum quality standards and parent engagement and communications parent

[04:04:48] communications can be a tool for parent engagement but really the if if we're going to help our students actually do better we've got to address all of those what's going on in the classroom and we're working on that absolutely i i am just happy to show how this pairs across you know the national landscape and snapshot yeah and then my question for ms muldoon and then i'll yield thank you madam president is um we were shown studies back when we started this process um i think it

[04:05:25] was fall of 23 or maybe even i'm sorry would you mind speaking closer to the microphone i'm just having sorry now it's too loud but we were shown studies uh back when we started this process Matt Chingos, who does, I think, great work at Urban Institute, I know you know, and I believe there's also some folks at Education Next, Daniel Hamlin and Paul Peterson, who've done work showing, well, as you know, a number of states over the last decade plus have realigned their cut scores.

[04:05:59] Many of them, and it shows in Mr. Cowan's charts too, were aligned closer to NAEP basic as we are and have made big, big movements, realigning their cut scores closer to NAEP proficient over the last couple of decades. And the analyses we were shown showed that that alone did not move student outcomes.

[04:06:20] In other words, it's a communications tool, but just realigning to NAEP proficiency instead of to NAEP basic doesn't in and of itself make students do better. Am I right? Or am I understanding that research right? Or do you have contrary research?

[04:06:36] Well, I'll say one caveat, just the nation's report card is better at telling us what's going on than why. That is, I think, just important to say. Second, I would say that from the, I think Jim, you know, and the work that they're doing on the honesty gap, that I would argue is very much about communicating and helping get the attention of parents and community members and others who have a stake in the student outcomes. I think for NAEP, the achievement levels are, and for any state assessment, achievement levels are more than a communications tool. They're intended to articulate what students should be aiming for, what teachers

[04:07:15] should be aiming for, and what set of skills the state, or in the case of NAEP, say students need to be able to demonstrate to be successful at the next level, whatever that, you know, whatever that is and i think that if um setting high standards for kids whatever that means is a necessary but not sufficient step to help them be to help the system right help teachers help parents help schools uh get students to that level right all students to that level well necessary but not

[04:07:53] sufficient you mean if you have great uh uh great teachers and great curriculum and allocating resources to your uh low low uh economic disadvantaged students etc etc you can get great results even if you have cut scores aligned with nape basic instead of nape proficiency am i wrong i think that in that case you might not be telling parents whether students are achieving at at the level that they need to be successful.

[04:08:23] - You might have the communications issue, but in other words, raising the cut scores alone does not move NAEP scores at all. - I don't think we have conclusive research that shows just changing cut scores, but I think that's the same as just raising your academic standards, just changing academic standards in the state we know is not enough.

[04:08:47] It's down to implementation and alignment of the systems. - But what we have is research to the contrary, raising cut scores alone is not going to make students do better on NAEP or in any other test. At least that's the research I've shown. And so if you've seen some different, that's what I'd love to know. But so I think I'm under, so then I'm trying to understand what is the theory of change for moving our cut scores from aligned with NAEP basic to NAEP proficient. And I think it's really primarily as a communications tool, which is back to Mr. Cowen's purpose, which can help with parent engagement? Is that the theory of change? Well, I certainly can't speak to the

[04:09:25] theory of change for a state. I will speak from the NAEP perspective and why we set the achievement levels at the level that we have for the last 30 plus years. And that is to articulate what knowledge and skills students need to have mastered in order to be prepared. And so that is, and again, as I said before, I think it is about communicating. And that's why I showed sample items right there's a whole lot more there's a lot of research that goes on behind that to articulate what does the test show students know and can do um so it's it is about communications

[04:09:59] but it is also about sending important signals to educators to students to families about the body of knowledge students need to attain so i would i would argue that's more than a communications it's about um it's a very clear articulation of the values and the goals towards which the system should be working. Just one more comment that I think the choice Virginia has made in the past, whether right or wrong, was not a choice that we didn't want our students mastering challenging material, but rather that we were aligning our cut scores to what we understood to

[04:10:35] be the minimum that a student needed to move to the next level. Whereas the choice to align to NAEP proficient, I'm hearing you say NAEP proficient is more has a student mastered challenging material for that grade level so that's really the difference between basic and proficiency the minimum necessary versus the challenging mastering challenging material and and states you know can choose to align with those definitions or not and i i think our my colleagues are ready for us to move uh to to aligning to the NAIC definitions but it's all

[04:11:12] definitional really um okay one or just for just one second um true or untrue did dr james lane when he was superintendent um recommend to the board certain cut scores that the board decided to go below his recommendation true or untrue we went slightly below on one or two tests it was not a reduction from a prior test because it was a new test but it was one or two very minor

[04:11:47] differences. It's nothing comparable to what we're talking about here, where Virginia has made a choice to be aligned to NAEP basic, not to NAEP proficient. Thank you. But raising a valid choice, it may be the wrong choice in this board. It may not be the choice this board wants to or should make now. But it was it was a it's a long standing thing. Not that affected 2019 NAEP results or the 2022 NAP results. I believe what Ms. Muldoon was talking about was the fact that when we raise cut scores, we raise expectations. And we believe that both our educators and our students are seeking

[04:12:25] the challenges of raising those expectations. And I, for one, believe in both our educators' ability to do that and our students' ability to meet those challenges, number one. So, Mr. Cowan, can you answer a question for me? Are you guys doing some work in the area of this big pervasive question, which is how many parents are okay with their child or their children simply being at basic?

[04:12:56] We have not done research on that yet. I know that there are some, some of that is in progress right now. I'd like to go back to one of the points that were made earlier about the difference between basic and proficient too. As a parent, I go back to the slide that Leslie showed, where you show like what does that mean to be basic what does that mean to be proficient those items are important to know i'm throwing out an example but if a if it's considered basic to be able to understand a point line system point line coordinate system at a certain grade

[04:13:32] and and suddenly we're changing that i'd like to know that as a parent that we have now altered what we're considering to be proficient because i think i think that's critical for a parent to have that understanding. Thank you, Dr. Northern. So I'm going to clear the deck here because I'm the researcher

on the panel. And there's been plenty of research in terms of what NAEP proficient means in terms of long term outcomes, which is all I frankly care about. Like I don't care if, you know, if if it's only going to correlate to, you know, your next year's GPA, that's one thing.

[04:14:11] But I want to know that it correlates to real long term outcomes that matter for kids in real life. And here's the research. A standard deviation on NAEP improvement in eighth grade math achievement on NAEP. So in other words, you're at NAEP proficient, right? And okay, now what does that mean in terms of long-term earnings and earned income? 1.6% decrease in the present value of lifetime earnings. But if you're actually NAEP proficient, you have about a $19,400 per student increase in earnings if you're Nate proficient that means that Nate

[04:14:50] proficient actually matters to your longtime earnings number two students born in states with larger increases in math proficiency at eighth grade saw higher rates of high school graduation and increased college enrollment this is not a randomized experiment study we don't have those but they're strong correlational studies have been year after year after year employment so okay

[04:15:15] This is this is really interesting to me. So kids who are proficient in higher math scores and are proficient, they're less likely to be unemployed. They are less likely to be teen girls born in states proficiency, less likely to become teen mothers, they're actually social outcomes. Proficiency on boys, you're less likely to be incarcerated at ages 18 to 24 lower. And then if you're not proficient, you have lower decline in high school graduation, lower declines in college enrollment.

[04:15:46] more increased likelihood of being pregnant as a teenager and more increased likelihood of arrest. So long term in cop dropout risk, I could go on and on and on and on. But my point is that NAEP proficiency matters in terms of long term outcomes for kids. I know this because I study it. And so this doesn't mean it's not just like, blah, blah, blah, let's just blow up our skirt and say we want to be NAEP proficient. It matters to kids in real term long term. I'm repeating myself, but that's where all of this should land i don't care about the politics i don't care about

[04:16:23] like oh we did this and we did this and who i mean that's called miss napery nobody knows why we are in the situation we're in we just know that we're in it and we're not about pointing fingers we're about saying okay this is what nate proficiency does for our kids and we should actually have that as our goal to do right by them madam president may i ask dr northern a follow-up question miss holton thank you i i totally concur with your summary of the research based on my reading of the research which i've also spent a lot of time with over the years my issue is whether

[04:16:58] there is any research that have so so nape scores correlate with good outcomes sol scores correlate with good outcomes. But whether our SOL cut scores align with NAEP cut scores or not, I think there's no research. The research shows there's no impact of realigning our cut scores. We need our students to do well on the tests, but where the line is, is irrelevant. That's the research that Matt Chingos and all showed us. I'm just saying, Ms. Holton, they're synonymous. No, they're not. No,

[04:17:36] no, no, no. If our SOL cut score was aligned to NAEP proficient, that's what we that's like. So for instance, on Ms. Muldoon's charts, we are at the bottom of the pack. No question about that. And should we move from that? Absolutely, we should. But we are at the bottom of the pack on our what you call what they call the honesty gap, the how our cut scores aligned to NAEP. But on our NAEP performance, we are average. Now, we want to be better than average, but our performance is average, so we are not bottom of the pack on our performance. The research shows that performance

[04:18:13] on NAEP outcomes correlates with all those life outcomes, but there's no research that I've seen that where you draw the cut scores correlates with NAEP outcomes, which, again, doesn't mean we shouldn't make this change, but it just makes the point that, you know, we're going to declare essentially the change that where we're heading is we're going to declare twice as many students not passing next year as this year. That doesn't mean our students are any dumber. It doesn't mean our teachers are any worse. It's just we've declared twice as many are failures because

[04:18:48] we've moved the line. That doesn't mean the students next year are going to have twice as high a likelihood of failure in all those life outcomes. They're still going to have the same Project of Life Outcomes. We've just moved the measurement, and the moving the measurement alone does not produce outcomes. I don't think it probably does any harm from the research I've seen, but it doesn't make any positive changes. What makes positive changes is work like what we're doing with the Literacy Act, the work we desperately need to continue to do on having a

[04:19:24] quality teacher in every classroom, especially for our high-poverty students who are not currently well being served. They're being served by provisional licensees, high turnover, etc., etc. So that's what we really need to do to move the needle. Dr. Northern? Of course I understand all that. It's not the point we're making. We all know all we need. The answer, high expectations are part of the larger puzzle of all of this. But I can guarantee you there's

[04:19:51] no state that has cut scores in the basement like ours, in the basement like ours on cut scores has low expectations for kids because low expectations are like a domino, right? Like you have low expectations here, you don't magically have them somewhere else. And actually, the test scores are where the rubber meets the road, right? Where all of these things that we know come into play, the disadvantage of so on and so forth. But at the end of the day, it's the same test. And it's holding all kids to the same rigor and level of achievement and I actually think that if we say okay we can move the bar really really really low and still expect that our kids are gonna raise up

[04:20:31] and do all these great things when we're not expecting them to do it it makes no sense it really doesn't make any sense so part of this is about NAEP proficiency in the research and part of it is about common sense and what signal do we send to kids when we actually set the cut score so dang low and you see a slide like that and you see Virginia way at the bottom on the cut scores it's embarrassing frankly we we need to do better as a state for our kids it's a communications tool miss halton mr hanson comments okay thank you ladies and gentlemen we appreciate uh your

[04:21:08] participation today your expertise um we thank you for being a part of our national expert series um you all have brought new fire to the discussion as you can see uh and we're grateful for for your contributions here today so thank you we are gonna go well I need you to go ahead and get motion here we are gonna switch back into our our licensure cases

[04:21:43] and so what we are gonna do now is I'll entertain a motion to go into closed session mr. Hanson I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes discussion or consideration by the Board of Education of Information relating to the denial, suspension, or revocation of teacher licenses subject to the exclusion in subdivision 11 of section 2.2-3705.2 pursuant to section 2.2-3711A40 of the Code of Virginia and consultation with legal counsel regarding

[04:22:21] specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant to Virginia Code section 2.2-37118 of the code of Virginia and the legal counsel to Virginia Board of Education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting. Is there a second? A motion has been made and seconded. All those in favor signify by saying aye. Aye. Any no? Okay. Motion carries. The board is now in executive session. All staff

[04:22:56] members and members of the public who have not been on. Okay. The chair will entertain a motion

[05:43:43] to certify the purpose of the meeting in closed session mr hansen we convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the freedom information act section 2.2-375 of the code of virginia requires the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard discussed or considered any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote indicating the

[05:44:22] substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place a statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes uh is there a second motion has been made and seconded this will be a roll call vote please signify by saying aye miss kilgore aye dr northern miss mcpherson miss holton mr hanson chair votes aye okay that motion carries okay um as we took up a number of cases today um i will ask for the board um to

[05:45:03] make such motions to follow in the case uh 2024-25 the board the chair will entertain a

[05:45:12] a motion to take no adverse action. I'll move. Is there a second? Dr. Northern? Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Holton? Abstain. And chair votes aye. In case 2025-03, the board, the chair will entertain a motion to issue a written reprimand to Joshua David Herndon. Is there a motion? Moved. Okay. Moved and seconded. Dr. Northern?

[05:45:55] Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. And Chair votes aye. In case 2025-01, Chair will entertain a motion to take no adverse action. Second. Okay.

[05:46:18] Moved and seconded, Dr. Northern? Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. And chair votes aye. In the case 2025-05, the chair will entertain a motion to issue a license.

[05:46:37] Second. Okay. Moved and seconded. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. And chair votes aye. Case 2025-04, chair will entertain a motion to revoke the license of John Edward Niles Jr.

[05:46:58] So moved. Moved and seconded. Dr. Northern? Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Hanson, Ms. McPherson, Ms. Holton, and chair votes aye. Okay, we are done with that portion of our meeting.

[05:47:19] So now we need to go back to item D or C. Okay, based on the fact that we have some people waiting in the waiting room to be a part of item E, I would ask that the board entertain this opportunity to skip over items C and D and move to item E.

[05:47:45] We will go back to item C and D after this presentation. I believe, Dr. Armstrong, this is you. No, not this one. The first part is North Dakota. Okay. So I guess Dr. Armstrong will come up later.

[05:48:04] But in December, several board members requested national feedback on seat time flexibility. And to that end, we have asked KnowledgeWorks and a member of the Mastery-Based Learning Team with the North Dakota Department of Education to present for us today.

[05:48:20] Then we'll hear from Dr. Armstrong and Dr. Coons about Virginia's notice and action kit in preparation for first review tomorrow at our business meeting. So I think we need to admit. Yes, please.

[05:48:35] Good afternoon.

[05:49:07] thank you for being with us today. So sorry that we're running a little bit off time schedule here, but are so glad that you're able to be with us to speak to us this afternoon. We are ready for you to introduce yourselves and proceed whenever you are. Great, thank you. This is Anne Ellison. I'm with the Department of Public Instruction in Bismarck, North Dakota. I want to confirm that our slides are currently being displayed? Or would you like me to share my screen?

[05:49:44] They're good. Yeah, they're up. Sorry, this is getting really loud. I'm sorry if I busted your eardrums. Yes, yes. Thank you. I will share my screen. How is that? Okay, perfect. So happy to meet you all. Anne Ellefson, as I said, I'm the Director of Academic Support in the North Dakota Department of Public Instruction. We want to thank Dr. Coons and members of the Virginia State board for inviting us here today to share with you some of our strategies lessons learned and different perspectives as we've pursued personalized learning throughout the state of north dakota

[05:50:25] as director of academic support in the dpi here in bismarck um we have a variety of projects and initiatives and one that i oversee is innovative education and the rollout and practices that we have within our schools and districts. When the first piece of legislation was issued in 2017 to do this work, we recognized that the state could not do this alone. We had limited capacity to support our 148 school districts and developed a strong partnership with KnowledgeWorks in order

[05:51:02] to support our schools and districts. So my KnowledgeWorks partner in crime is Lori Phillips and I'll let her introduce herself. Thank you, Superintendent Koons, Chair Creasy, and members of the State Board of Education for having us. I am a grateful partner to Anne in North Dakota and I am a Senior Director of Teaching and Learning at KnowledgeWorks and lucky enough to work across the country and have been working in North Dakota alongside Anne and her team for This is Year 8.

[05:51:31] so grateful to be here thanks laurie so as we prepared for today's session with you all we thought we would go ahead and share north dakota's approaches to innovative education what that's looked like throughout this journey and then also kind of in tandem between laurie and myself give examples of what this work actually looks like occurring in schools and districts across our state so we'll share some information we'll have time for questions at the end but should you have questions as we navigate please feel free to to interrupt so as i mentioned

[05:52:09] the partnership between knowledge works and in particular lori phillips and the department of public instruction really grew out of an organic place we recognize our schools and districts needed support that was beyond what we at the state department had capacity to provide or understand through our eight years together we support each other through thought partnership as we write grants or develop policy or practice within our state we really work hand in hand with each other i will say that the knowledge works team brings together a policy a practice team

[05:52:48] and also some visioning that has been a benefit to the state of north dakota are also our assessment offices and other offices within the department of public instruction have also utilize knowledge works as a sounding board for design and development we've also provided design and facilitation for district level supports so schools and districts that have pursued innovative education models what does that roadmap look like and knowledge works has helped to guide that roadmap through innovative education we do recognize that district leaders need to behave differently and receive supports differently so knowledge works has been able to

[05:53:28] also provide additional support coaching mentoring on district leadership really i think when you get into innovative education in schools you need an an entrepreneur of education sometimes more than a superintendent of education so you really have to have that entrepreneur mindset or be a superintendent and an entrepreneur at the same time so we've been able to provide our school districts with that leadership support and development there are also some logistical pieces that we'll get through such as our learning continuum where knowledge works has been instrumental in the design like reaching to other states and facilitation of bringing north dakota

[05:54:07] educators together we've moved through this journey and now we're in a place where we have a statewide network where we have north dakota educators north dakota leaders providing strategies to spread and scale personalized learning to each other to help lift and support so the journey with knowledge works has been robust and i will say that north dakota would not be where they're at without a partner like knowledge works at um at the table so now a little bit about our statewide

[05:54:40] flexibilities in north dakota we have the innovative education program in place my understanding is in virginia you all you all refer to that as your seat time flexibility north dakota has its innovative education so when i say that that i believe is the context that you all will look through it when we work with our schools and districts often they will want to find the one piece of statute that might be in their way the one piece of law that might be there in their way and that really is not the approach that we take with our innovative education program

[05:55:18] rather we ask for our schools and districts to design a comprehensive plan a systems level plan that looks at what's their rationale and and vision for innovative education what does this look like at the systems level how do they know that this is what their stakeholders want and need stakeholders include their teachers their students their community parent members board members and so forth there is a level of board approval because we know that pursuing innovative education is it's a tax on time and development of staff and we really need to

[05:55:54] to behave differently in schools that are moving towards innovation. Also, the level of support provided for professional development for educators has to be articulated, and how is that supported throughout the process. And then we look at implementation and continuous improvement. What we've learned is that some schools that have had an innovative waiver in place since 2017, they've iterated along the way. You only know what you know as you design your system, and so we've had to be responsive to that to their continuous needs on an ongoing basis there is also

[05:56:33] an element of evaluation and sustainability where we report to our state legislature on an annual basis regarding progress and outcomes for the innovative education schools as we've learned since 2017 these schools it's important that they have a community in which they can learn from one another

and with one another um often it's an isolating experience if you're trying to innovate a system all on your own the other thing that north dakota has done uniquely we believe

[05:57:07] it's uniquely is that the state has approached this work to learn from our schools and districts that have pursue innovative education so the state is in a true partnership with these schools and districts and then we leverage that partnership to adjust our practices and inform our policy we've seen changes to our north dakota century code and administrative code as a direct result of practices that are happening in classrooms schools and districts that are practicing innovation so we're able to address those barriers that were on their original list with more context and true examples of what it looks like that's a little bit of ground setting

[05:57:47] for the next part of our slides on this screen you'll see our innovative education timeline so i did begin explaining in 2017 when our partnership really started with knowledge works but prior to that in 2015 superintendent kirsten basler was elected to the to the superintendency of north dakota she was um a fresh person in that position prior to that Dr. Wayne Sandstead served for 28 years. So Dr. Lisa Coons, you have a little bit of time if you want to beat Wayne Sandstead's record. 28 years as state superintendent.

[05:58:26] And so Superintendent Baszler stepped in with her ears wide open and many of our schools and districts in 2015-17 said, "Here's the flexibility that we need." And in North Dakota, we have everything from one-room schoolhouses to large comprehensive high schools with thousands of students and their needs were vastly different but we recognized we needed to provide some form of flexibility for that work to look different in these different environments so with um listening gathering information from our schools districts advocates from 2015 to 17 we then pursued this

[05:59:01] journey with knowledge works at our right hand in this timeline that you'll see so we'll be referencing back to this slide or to especially the titles and colors on this slide as the next few um as the next section section pursues so our first major legis piece of legislation was senate bill 2186 which is our innovative education bill this was passed in 2017 and allows for that school or district to design a comprehensive plan for improvement it allowed the state superintendent

[05:59:38] to waive a laundry list of sections of century code and every every other year we meet on a on a biannual basis our legislative assembly this section of code is updated with additional areas where superintendent basler may wait may wave statute and authority districts that do pursue the innovative education program have one year of planning so recognizing that it takes time to bring teachers community members and so forth a minimum of one year of planning to bring those individuals together to design and then there they receive a waiver for five years of implementation

[06:00:15] under that plan as i mentioned we have some schools that started this in 2017 and they're on their second set of five years for ongoing implementation i also mentioned that we collect reports on an annual basis from these schools and districts and report regularly to our legislative assembly lori i'm going to share it with you for a little bit and then i can provide some further context on what this looks like in north dakota absolutely so empower ed is a program within the bismarck city schools or public schools i'm one of the largest districts in the state

[06:00:52] the empower ed program started in 2020 their mission is to empower learners to thrive and take control of their own learning so they really started small they took advantage of the innovation waiver and then also the innovation academy which is in alignment with that waiver and it provided support for

bismarck leaders to come together and to be able to design and iterate with others to develop this program so out of the innovation academy they started small with a small group of

[06:01:25] kids in 2020 and that has continued to grow over time and now the empower ed program is at two different high schools two different campuses um it really embeds community projects it is competency-based um we have had the privilege of engaging with many learners within the empowered program and the level with which the learners can describe what they're learning can drive what that learning looks like they drive you know how they spend their time when they need to show up um and

[06:02:01] what they need to work on and what they're trying to accomplish and they're very articulate um about all of that so i think empower ed is certainly delivering on the mission they iterate constantly and try to meet learners where they are it is open and accessible to all although they say maybe not for everyone you know everyone may not want to take advantage of the style of learning but it is open to all so that's one way that i would say the innovation waiver has taken root within an actual school and district and what would you add there yeah i would add um you're

[06:02:35] right that it began small almost like a school within a school type of structure it's important to note that the original design is in a career academy that does not issue its own high school diplomas so it is a separate structure a cte a career and tech ed building within the bismarck public school districts where the comprehensive high schools have kids that attend there what the school knew and noticed is that their kids were sometimes very successful in their cte programming where maybe they may be less engaged in their content level programming back at their regular

[06:03:14] high school so the empowered program allows them to bring both of those pieces together and fold in community work out community outreach and work outside of that school lori did indicate that they started small i believe the original design they're like hey can we do those five kids and then eventually it moved up to 25 that very first year and now they have over 100 kids per semester and also have a second site within a comprehensive high school campus so again getting the learning to look different and really the adults in the system

[06:03:51] to behave different the instruction has to look different for students the learning has to look different for students and for that to happen adults need to understand that learning at a different level because it's not the same delivery as high school as most of us probably had participated in i also think it's pretty cool that the kids have renamed this program they've designed the logo for this program there's a lot of local ownership for the empowered program that's

[06:04:22] generated directly from students our number one customer in public education in 2018 as we mentioned the law passed in 2017 in 2018 i was fortunate to receive a bunch of phone calls from schools and districts that said hey we want to do the innovative education program where do we begin and um you know that's that's really hard because where do you want to begin what are the needs of your community what um what are your stakeholder needs where are you currently at what is your design and vision for the future so other than providing deep thought questions and coaching

[06:05:01] with schools and districts the state agency didn't have capacity to figure out how do we support schools that want to design systems differently when our expertise was within our current century code our current instructional understanding and so forth this is where we developed a partnership a really multi-partner approach knowledge works is our longest standing partner that came to the table but we

also need to shout out the bush foundation who provided financial funding behind our personalized competency-based learning cohort this was a

[06:05:38] five-year commitment between north dakota knowledge works and the bush foundation on how might we provide supports to educators across north dakota in personalized competency-based learning so the application process aligned very clearly with our innovative education application under 2186 the schools and districts that were interested had to agree to multi-year commitment for implementation as well as systems level changes so that looked very different in our largest comprehensive high school which has 11 to 12 000 students to some of our smallest

[06:06:17] schools that have k-12 maybe 500 students in north dakota when we roll out pilots and programs we feel it's really important for our schools to see themselves within the model schools that are there i would imagine in your state as well you have large schools and small schools if you only provide an opportunity to your large schools those small schools are like well that's easy for them they have coaches they have a building principal and our small schools are like my building principal is driving the bus and coaching volleyball tonight um so you have we had we intentionally provided environments in which other schools could see themselves some of our

[06:06:57] larger school districts down to smaller school districts so um this began in 2018 and lasted actually six years because of the pandemic slowed our progress it didn't derail the progress but we had a lot of virtual meetings for a few years there so um it did slow that progress lori i'll let you talk a little bit here about what the cohort looked like thanks ann so this was really when knowledge works began i would say to have some district level partnerships always in tandem

[06:07:32] with Ann and the department. We had districts apply. We put out an RFP. I think it's important to recognize that there were five districts who began this journey and talked about it earlier. Leadership development and leadership capacity is really important. So we had four districts who persisted. Area size districts, West Fargo being the largest district in the cohort, they are consistently adding schools and growing so upwards of 12 000 kids northern cast it's

[06:08:08] important to say that they were out in front northern cast was probably about five years into their journey at the point that they started um this cohort and due to a really strong relationship with anna the department she said this is going to be good for you you should join this um oaks has around 550 kids they were starting at the beginning and then the marmot wolves in the lower left-hand corner had our heart from the beginning that is a high school within the department of corrections um and that's the youth correctional center so they brought a unique

[06:08:46] perspective to this cohort as they are meeting kids needs in all areas um not just including academics and they had a lot for the rest of us to learn from um so it's important to say when you're bringing districts together that are at all different entry points you know northern cast yes had a lot to share with the rest of the group but they also needed to feel that they could learn and grow and they were going to be stretched and challenged and so we needed to walk the walk and say can we personalize an experience for adults in a way that we're asking and we can

[06:09:22] model that or we want them to do that with kids in classrooms and educators and buildings you know from the leadership level so i would say one of our biggest challenges was we were looking at the sustainability and the long game here to say we want this not to just be five to six years of really great professional learning we need them to build collective efficacy we need them to depend on each other

value each other begin to share resources and recognize that they can't do this alone and there is strength in numbers and so would they continue to collaborate long after

[06:10:02] this cohort ended and ann and i can be really transparent to say that we were probably four years in still you know kind of scratching our heads to say west fargo is a large district really wondered how they could learn from a small district that was rural and vice versa they're different they have different challenges we're unique they all feel that way and they're all correct but they can still learn from one another and so i would say one of the biggest levers coming out of covid was we started to have the districts host site visits so each of them agreed that per

[06:10:38] year they would host two to three site visits within the cohort and they started to recognize as they sent educator teams to each other you know west fargo sent a group of middle school educators down to oaks and they came back and said okay we're going to take more they really didn't feel it was going to be relevant and they learned quickly that small school large school we all have kids in classrooms and we're all trying to innovate and personalize that experience and they had they they really started to recognize they could learn from each other and they didn't

[06:11:11] had to re have to recreate the wheel all the time and so that was huge um we also this cohort was about transforming systems and so systems change second order change is something that's not intuitive i think you know many of the districts wanted to close their doors and they really wanted to focus on building up their own skills and creating their own capacity and said wait a minute we don't have time right now to worry about what anyone else is in the state is doing so it took quite a while for them to recognize that they needed to help pave the way for others and that

[06:11:49] was a responsibility being a part of this cohort yes deepen your own system transform your system pave the way for others and so i think throughout covid a little bit of a happy accident in some of those virtual meetings we began to utilize them as thought leaders so they helped to create a personally learning framework that you're going to see um coming up next they started to think about what are some of those tenants you know that that we believe play out differently but they unify us all and so some of those pieces have helped get us a little bit closer to this idea of sustainability

[06:12:28] and once the official cohort ended last fall the districts are through the network continuing to reach out to each other continuing to ask questions share resources um and it's it's incredible to see and i i don't know that ann and i thought always that was going to happen so that's i would say a big highlight ann anything you would add thanks um laurie the other thing i would say is from the state perspective it was really important that we design and the we have these um personalized

[06:13:03] learning framework elements with some key definitions and look for is within them on the surface let's say build relationships with students it's easy for schools to say yeah yeah we already do that we do that that's a part of our RTIB that's a part of our MTSS but really when you look at it we're looking at those meaningful relationships between the adults and educators or adults and students students to students we really believe in a level of personalization especially when it comes to their work so their work can support that relationship development

[06:13:44] throughout so what i would say especially as we've pursued innovative education being clear and articulate on your state structures not necessarily as a you know no your mtss system doesn't necessarily do it exactly this way but allowing out people to see where see themselves within your framework and understand how they continue to learn grow and deepen within that framework that

already exists another piece that's been very important in north dakota's work has been a portrait of a graduate and you'll hear about portrait of a graduate when you hear from

[06:14:23] a lot of states that pursue innovative education or personalized learning in north dakota this was developed under governor doug burgum and what we found was as our districts worked through their local processes on personalized learning they went through a process to define their local portrait of a graduate and as we continue to have conversations on state policy or at that level above the school districts having a structure and a framework and a common language for those other entities was critical one of the things in north dakota the portrait of a graduate is not required

[06:15:01] it's not required in statute it's not required that anybody has to have a portrait of a graduate what it does provide is it provides a north star for the state of north dakota for educators and learners and our school systems to aim towards this was very helpful especially in the legislative session to have that common language and those stakeholders whether they be k-12 advocates business and industry all kind of speaking to those same pieces on this slide you'll see the

[06:15:34] 2021 portion of a graduate that was designed and developed we had over 100 stakeholders everything from business and industry to non-public schools to students to educational leaders a part of this process so this was developed under the governor's office but it's become a foundational element that we've been able to build into our other practices such as the north dakota learning continuum so in 2021 that legislative session our schools and districts said the innovative

[06:16:10] education program is great we'd like some flexibility on a graduation pathway that might look different than your traditional four courses in english let's say so senate Senate Bill 2196 provided the state superintendent the authority to create a learning continuum and it also provided flexibility for a mastery framework.

[06:16:37] We'll talk about what that means in a second. But for the learning continuum, we felt that this was a critical piece for our schools and districts in order to fully transform their systems to a personalized competency-based system. provides a structure for integrated and engaging learning opportunities, allowing for mastering essential knowledge skills and dispositions that align to the students post-secondary career or military interests. North Dakota has a vision that all students will graduate choice-ready with the knowledge, skills, and dispositions to be successful. That's in post-secondary,

[06:17:16] career, or military. So this portrait of a graduate on the prior slide became a foundational element for our North Dakota learning continuum. Our learning continuum has elements that are, as I said, aligned to the essential skills of the portrait of a graduate. Also, we have those overarching skills in English language arts, math, science, and social studies. Lori, I'll let you speak to a little bit about that process when we actually designed it in 2022? Thanks, Anne. So in

[06:17:53] 2022, again, it was, you know, we thought we could do this in person and realized that actually virtually was a little more efficient. So KnowledgeWorks in tandem with GPI, we led a process to bring educators from all across the state, not just educators who were in the original cohort.

[06:18:14] We were really intentional to say we need educators from different regions. We had the REAs, which are regional education associations, be a part of it. When it came to the attributes from the profile of a graduate, there were some folks who were counselors, some who were maybe coming from social

work, brought stakeholders together and said, okay, what are the attributes here that we believe are essential?

[06:18:44] And when we talk about the attributes, we're scaling up to be more broad from the standards realm. So standards don't go away, but we really needed to help educators and leaders understand the difference between the granularity level of a standard up to a priority standard up to then a competency.

[06:19:04] And so thinking about a lot of people had fear that standards would go away. Standards still have a place. They are the vehicle that learners will actually use to practice and show mastery of these skill-based competencies, but a competency really is meant to be a cross-cutting skill or concept.

[06:19:24] So as Anne said, if you look at the North Dakota Learning Continuum, you will see headings, which we think is a baby step, a training wheel. Some may always leave it there, that you will see social studies as a category. But if you look underneath social studies at those attributes, if you removed social studies as the topic area, they could be practiced across the board in all content areas.

[06:19:49] So we really feel as though the educators and, you know, other stakeholders that came together, it was such an aha for them to think about what do we truly want kids to know and be able to do. and then when they walk across that stage we're saying that they have mastered all of these they might practice them with different standards but we're saying that being an engaged citizen or engaged citizenship is important for all and so it was um i think it was one of ann and i we walked away one of our proudest moments um to be candid i think districts are still struggling to

[06:20:28] implement there were some really great deep conversations and now putting it into practice looking at these grade banded progressions um is is a different matter and so thinking about what comes next in order to help them operationalize a document such as this thanks lori so the piece that puts this into action in schools and districts was the second part of senate bill 2196 that went along with the learning continuum and this allowed for schools and districts to create a mastery framework policy so local school boards could create a policy that really provides that

[06:21:08] alternative graduation pathway different than what's required currently in statute however that mastery framework policy must meet or exceed the north dakota learning continuum so as lori said this is an area where we see our districts may be struggling on what does that look like and it might be easy to identify what it looks like for a certain group of kids or a certain student within their system but we're really thinking about the systems level so what does mastery look like at an opportunity for any student and again we believe that instruction

[06:21:46] and learning has to look different in order for the mastery framework to be used to its full potential as aligned to their local innovative education plan so the mastery framework we do see it occurring in one of our schools in northern cast that was one of the schools that was a part of our pcbl cohort they continue to be a leader in this work in the state and in the nation and lori i'll let you explain a little bit about what we see happening in their studio models really

[06:22:19] where that learning looks vastly different than a traditional school model absolutely so northern cast decided they're they're always a how do we get to yes district um and always looking to put learning in the hands of of their learners and kids and so they learned i believe and it was i iowa i want to say iowa idaho um they went and visited they learned they saw you know that district implementing or

that state the studio model and came back and said you know our middle school learners are languishing a little bit we're looking for something different at the middle

[06:22:57] school level so that's where they started they started to say you know what we still do have foundational skills that kids need to learn in some standards that are those priority standards that are not going to go away but can we make space within the middle school day where kids can learn in a studio. And right now it's still pretty, I would say, educator-led where the educators are creating studios that are more of a performance, I would say, leading into a performance assessment where there's a scenario. And so there may be car crash physics. But wrapped within that six-week

[06:23:37] experience for kids, there are identified competencies and there are identified standards that kids will be able to master as they move through that studio a piece that I want to make sure that you know is that the learning continuum really was meant for districts to adopt if they needed to adopt it and didn't have the capacity to go through that productive struggle and create their own northern cast is a district that had done some of that legwork so they did not take the North Dakota Learning Continuum and just adopt as is. So Dr. Corey Steiner and team,

[06:24:15] they wanted to match local language. They wanted to align to their focus areas. So they have taken, you know, and Ann said it has to be, the Learning Continuum is the floor, you know, so they had to go above and beyond that. So they have their own take on the Learning Continuum. And another piece of their studio is there has to be an expert in expert out. So they really are bringing in community experts and community partners that have to be a part of the studio experience for kids.

[06:24:48] Kids get to join and decide which one they want to be a part of. And now kids are starting to recognize I could have a different end product than, you know, someone working next to me in this group and because of that I might bring in a different competency I might bring in a different standard and so there are some baked in but there are also room for kids to have voice and then you have some educators who are working with the kids and this has now flowed up to the the secondary level and it plan is for it to flow down into the elementary but they're working with kids as coaches

[06:25:25] is to say, you are in need of this, this, and this competency. How could we put a studio together for you that is something that you're interested in and that it's something that you can work through and you will master the competencies that you need to master while also being in a preferred learning experience that aligns to your goals. So they've seen a lot of success with that, even in remediation at the secondary level. And so a lot of room to grow, but they've been the district to take advantage of senate bill 2196 in this way thanks laurie and then lastly what

[06:26:04] we'd like to talk about is kind of as this work has evolved since our partnership with knowledge works in 2018 we brought these schools and districts together they are part of a cohort they've since evolved with our funding with the bush foundation is done and as laurie indicated you know we kind of were like is anyone going to still be engaged after this work what it currently looks like is our cohort has merged into a North Dakota network for personalized learning we still recognize that districts need support beyond what the state agency can provide they've leaned on one

[06:26:40] another to receive that support and have a place for thought partnership for expertise for others North Dakota personnel to share their learning and experiences in our network for personalized learning we really focus on a few areas in particular what does learning and growth for the educator look like um what is learning and growth for students look like how do we share progress and spread the word

of the personalized learning happening throughout the state provide leadership coaching and development as we indicated we believe that we need entrepreneurs

[06:27:16] within educational systems so that needs to look a little bit different especially in innovative environments and then always focusing on continuous improvement for the network for the schools themselves and on a broader scale so throughout this journey um we recognize that you know our school systems they're not starting brand new and starting from scratch um on this work i'll often say like it's trying to compete for that top chef competition between 5 30 to 6 30 at night in my kitchen like that's probably not the best time for me to become the specialized at my craft if

[06:27:53] i'm trying to focus on that systems level scale others will say it's like remodeling your house while still living inside and having all those functioning parts and parties that you may be hosting um we're asking our school systems to live in the current and provide something different so supports resources technical assistance and being really adaptable in what that looks like is very important we find some of our smaller districts they might not have coaching capacity as i said their person is wearing 14 different hats much less a coaching hat versus our larger

[06:28:30] districts might have coaching supports and structures but how do you ensure all 15 of your coaches are on the same page so the needs and supports look different between all in that personalized learning cohort um lori i'll let you speak a little bit about this next slide and then we'll be ready for questions okay the north dakota network for personalized learning launched last year um as ann said it really did evolve out of the cohort and so a lot of the local leadership um i will say that ann and i are behind this string the scenes still maybe pulling some of

[06:29:08] those strings as the handoff isn't completely ready yet or clean um and so as the knowledge works representative who feels like a local in north dakota i still am directing this network but very behind the scenes at this point you're not going to see knowledge works name on something at this point you're not going to see something likely coming from lori phillips when we talk local leadership we decided that the network could focus on learning opportunities opportunities to share districts and educators always going to see what does it look like and they feel they

[06:29:43] have to travel across the country to see something great in another classroom and they don't things are things are great things are happening even within their own district maybe they don't get the chance to walk down the hall and it's definitely happening across districts in the state and then this idea of impact and improvement how are we measuring not only the progress of the network but how are we measuring the progress of personalized practices so right now there are three coordinators that are heading up those learn share and impact improvement teams and those are coming straight out of the districts um we have tom clap out of northern cast who is leading

[06:30:21] the learning opportunities he is still doing his current full-time job but believes in this and his superintendent dr cory steiner said we i would be a fool not to want him to do this work because he's going to bring as much back to northern cast as he's contributing and this overlaps with the work he's doing for our district so absolutely it makes sense um so we have people from bismarck from west fargo from other districts who are doing the the the leadership and they're doing like the contribution into the network um instead of it continuing to be the lori and ann show

[06:31:00] who then are just providing opportunities that may not meet the needs um but it's coming straight from those who are looking for the impact. So lots and lots and lots of iteration and room to grow.

Today, as we speak, there were two learning workshops happening in Fargo and in Bismarck, and Ann and I were not a part of them. So years ago, we would have been leading them, creating the agendas, doing all the things, and now they're happening and we are guiding, you know, from the side. So it's exciting. It's exciting to see where it's going to go

[06:31:36] and exciting to see how north dakota can continue to work towards that sustainable network um where they can learn and grow within the state thank you laurie so um superintendent coons and madam chair we will gladly stand for any questions that you might have or additional information that you would like to learn about north dakota knowledge works or the support we to provide to our schools and districts thank you so much for your presentation we really do

[06:32:06] appreciate it are there any questions from board members dr northern why did heads turn down here i know i did i did ask for the presentation um all right i've got several questions but i will be brief and hopefully some of them won't be too long um one i'm just curious what was waived right you said at the beginning that you know there were certain things they wanted wave so what is it that has to be waived that's getting in everybody's way the most the most cumbersome legislation

[06:32:39] um or guideline two is when you're talking about what um you know what do you have to do necessary for graduation let's just look at the portions of the learning continuum my concern was that you are prioritizing skills over content so just kind of make me feel better there because i think it's easier to prioritize skills when you're talking about a framework like this versus particular content to be mastered and i'm curious whether you had to actually alter any course requirements for graduation so we're all familiar with four four courses of ela and three

[06:33:15] of math and three of science but what we're seeing across the country is that like you can't fit it all in um and so i'm just curious like do you have like you know opportunities where they can finish all their course requirements by 10th grade for example and do innovative personalized programs whatever in 11th and 12th grade so i'm just trying to figure out how you're cramming everything in because it seems to me like something's got to go and then my other question is on the bush foundation honestly just was curious like um you know is your sense that all of these programs

[06:33:53] really did require foundational additional foundation support and i promise my last one i hope you wrote these down it's just on quality control i've been concerned that we are all about innovation and we are but we also need to make sure that these programs are producing outcomes for kids so talk to us a little bit about how you view quality control and honestly if that's too much we can do some of this off yeah thank you for those questions um i didn't catch your full name but um i will go ahead and answer um what we're what we're able to hear so

[06:34:29] when a school writes its comprehensive plan i will tell you most of them like it's like well it's seat time seat time is my problem i need to figure out seat time it's the number of hours that they have to have for the unit of study and for cte it's higher and um in my experience that's too narrow of their thinking so if they think about the statute that's in their way they um they think too narrow so when you really challenge your schools and districts to think about like what would your ideal school system look like do the kids have to walk through a threshold to be counted

[06:35:06] in attendance to receive learning instruction and ultimately payment like so they think of this broad plan that comes into the state agency and then people like myself who read the sentry code on a regular basis and know all the different numbers that a school district doesn't like they know the

repercussions of seat time but they don't need to know the sentry code elements so to answer your question specifically what we after review the plan we call out in that plan and literally redline it and say well they're going to need seek time flexibility here they're going to need teacher licensure flexibility here they're going to need

[06:35:46] flexibility on learn we call it learn everywhere but we're like learning might happen at boy scouts and they bring that learning in and work with maybe a literacy coach maybe it's a personalized learning coach where the teacher of record might not be the master of english language arts but they consult with the master of english english arts we see flexibilities in internships and externships and apprenticeships the other thing that we're seeing some flexibility that comes up naturally after they're implementing we have some dual credit some higher education

[06:36:25] requirements and you have to be this this many years old to be able to participate we're able to accelerate that because we're able to prove these students are ready for maybe some dual credit access courses or even beyond what our typical english 110 might be and they're on a more accelerated path so the flexibility that our legislature was able to provide to superintendent basler um at first it was drafted that she could waive anything in statute like including the speed limit um so we had to revise that but there is flexibility that even for something like dual

[06:37:04] credit that is not overseen out of our k-12 education that's our higher education institutions um and through the university system we do have authority to waive that section of statute if it's in the way of kids so i think that's the number one there that's great i'm going to talk about quality control real quick so when we um when we passed the bill for innovative education there is an element of quality control from local districts reporting their progress um and you know they're

[06:37:42] busy they're busy teaching at the same time they're trying to figure out their evaluation and their progress what i'd like to say that has been probably one of the biggest impacts of that bush foundation investment in our pcbl work was a longitudinal study so there are multi-partners KnowledgeWorks is primary partner number one and my best friend. Lori's my best friend in work regarding all of this work. But one of the partners that came to the table is WestEd.

[06:38:08] So WestEd has done a comprehensive study during our six years under this work. And actually today I had a call with WestEd. They're not under contract with the Bush Foundation. They're not under contract with KnowledgeWorks. But they've come back to the state of North Dakota and said, hey, we want to update on our data. We're two years past their research. They want to do a refresh on that data to look at the longstanding impacts of this work. So again, it's about partnerships and relationships, not necessarily contracted services from vendors to get this work

[06:38:47] done. So there is an element of quality control. We have positive progress. We had some flatline progress in in some of this work what we did see out of the research is students that participated in districts that had a personalized competency-based learning approach they attended school more often that includes during the pandemic and they're more engaged in school and we saw some academic indicators as well I do want to put an asterisk on that though if we look at the school sizes

[06:39:21] like the n size is tough our ycc school which is the adjudicated youth they had very small numbers so they were not in that and then our largest school west bargo is a really big school so like they could easily shift our data one way or another but um we're continuing to monitor those trends in that

broader research as well as local districts reporting what that looks like um graduation lori i should pause do you have anything to add on the waiver or the quality

[06:39:55] control i've heard yep what i've heard so far is that um and west ed evaluation was that something your general assembly put in a put in to fund that evaluation where did the funding just ask are we going to continue to fund that evaluation yeah who funded the west ed evaluation so the original funding for the west ed evaluation was part of the bush foundation's expectation and work so that was provided originally i believe west but but again keeping my network ended in

[06:40:28] oh 23 i think spring of 23 and so as i said today we're still having meetings with them even though they're not in under contract to provide a continued report for north dakota thank you yeah and i would say i don't have anything to add um in what you've already talked about but I can certainly begin to speak to the prioritizing skills over content and the idea that that potentially is easier. And so I think when you look at the learning continuum and you

[06:41:05] see the skills that are listed there, what isn't listed there are still those priority standards that kids are going to be working towards. You know, no one is going to say that kids still don't need to know how to read to write to there there are math standards that are really necessary um what i think that the learning continuum does is prioritizes application and so when you think about potentially traditional math classes and i'll speak for myself you know i was able to do all of the discrete skills but i couldn't apply it when i got to college i received a d minus

[06:41:42] in a stats class. And the feedback they gave me was cannot apply. And so I think it's putting kids in situations that when you ask kids and we talk to the kids in the Bismarck Empowered program, they're going to say, you know what, this is harder. And they don't choose to take all courses in Empower Ed. They might choose to take an economics course, but they go ahead and go back to their homeschool and take social studies. And when I asked them why, they said, because it's a lot more work. So I'm only going to do it in something that I really care about and I'm really interested in because I have to come up with my plan. I have to figure out how I'm going

[06:42:21] to show and demonstrate mastery here. It feels a lot more cumbersome to kids, but they'll also say it's a lot more meaningful. And so I think this idea of, you know, easier, Anne and I certainly with Senate Bill 2196, we had a lot of conversations behind the scenes that said, you know, could there be some districts who graduated kids for just being really good people, you know, and how do we, how do we keep that from happening? And so what I would say is you can't, and I think you can't now

[06:42:58] in the current system. But Anne, I see that you've brought up the learning continuum, you know, piece here. And so I think it really is still a combination of those standards with the skills being, if you could forgive me and I can use a sports analogy, you know, I think the content used to be the end zone. And now we've made this idea of kids being able to problem solve, that's the end zone. And we're going to use the standards as the way that they get there and practice that. And what will you add from this?

[06:43:34] Yeah, I just thought it would pull up this slide that we often share as we talk through the learning continuum and in our traditional model, we have North Dakota has standards and it's required that our courses must meet or exceed those standards. Oftentimes schools deliver the course, right? It's an English 9, English 10, English 11, those four English courses. And I have two high schoolers right now. If they sit long enough, if they jump through the hoops, if they do their homework, they get that unit of credit the learning isn't necessarily driving the issue of the credit or what that

[06:44:13] looks like not in every situation i must say but in a in our traditional model that we see in many of our schools under the competency-based learning and mastery framework the basis yes the standards are there the the this the learning of those um of those standards is still a piece but the focus on that essential overarching element in that learning continuum. I'm going to flip to another slide real quick that shows. This is just an example from the learning continuum where critical

[06:44:47] reading might be that competency that we're aiming for. The learning might come through ELA. It might come through social studies. It might come through my Eagle Scout badge. It might come in a lot of different ways. That's for a local district to design and develop like what is a sandbox in which this can operate that then is captured within that mastery framework our law does not require a district with an approved mastery framework policy to back map it to four english credits in a traditional model they have to back map it even a competency-based system often has to say

[06:45:25] well you did english 9 10 11 12. our system including the state scholarship allows for mastery to be documented according to that learning continuum and then that that credit that recognition um occurs the other thing that i think is important is like the example that i had back here for grade six through eight that doesn't mean you master this in eighth grade i mean good good gracious i'm probably still working on some of these and i'm a well-seasoned adult um so we have many times throughout our educational career that we would focus on and i'll maybe this slide would

[06:46:05] be helpful for you to see too those overarching academic attributes what they look like in practice and multiple times throughout our career what we and what we are not seeing even in schools that have the mastery framework we are seeing that their kids are coming with the ability to apply those standards in real life settings and in ways that make their learning more relatable, more actionable, more meaningful to themselves. And learning becomes much more fun and much more

[06:46:39] engaging. And something I think we want to also like reiterate is that there really aren't big swings here. Someone is not going to take, you know, this learning continuum and Senate Bill 2196 and just go implement all of it you know all at once so when when dr steiner and northern cast decided to begin down the road of the studio model they took some small steps you saw the empowered program started with you know 20 25 kids so really trying to i think get some proof of concept there

[06:47:15] before so start small scale fast you know iterate iterate iterate and so there really are small iterations that have a large impact you know that that we're going for and i believe there was one more question the bush foundation but i don't recall what it was it's okay it's you guys have done great yeah i'm good thank you guys thank you all so much we really do appreciate you presenting

[06:47:48] for us today um so thank you for taking the time that you did with us um and we will certainly be in touch as we move forward to continue to seek your advice and your counsel as we move through this process so thank you yes thank you very much i appreciate the opportunity thank you thank you okay so as promised dr coons and dr armstrong will be presenting if you look at your um sharepoint

[06:48:25] it's the second presentation and i think this one's going to be brief and after this presentation will take a very quick break so that we can determine whether or not we have to leave here at 4 30. Okay thanks. Well I really want to appreciate KnowledgeWorks in North Dakota who as you saw in their timeline has been doing this for quite some time working on innovation working on iteration. Some of the things that they shared with us were some of the things that we heard as we've gone through extensive feedback.

The start small scale fast. The thoughts around networking. I think starting with needs instead of starting with statutes and

[06:49:03] waivers has been a really clear focus of ours. As they said, they're calling this personalized learning. As we looked across the country, some people are calling this mastery based learning. Some people are calling this competency based. We have given this the umbrella seat time flex because that's where the legislation landed. But we're really excited to talk to you about today is what we've heard as we've done extensive stakeholder engagement, feedback sessions, listened, and talked to our lab school networks. We really are excited about spreading and learning from the innovation we have. And I think they talked about a network, and we are excited that there is an innovation conference, April 22nd through the 24th, and one of the key

[06:49:42] pieces of that conference will be design thinking, and any school, any school division can go to that conference and start this opportunity for design thinking around House Bill 1477 and design thinking and seed time flex. I'm going to turn it over to Dr. Armstrong to take us through.

[06:49:59] Good afternoon, Madam President, Board members. Start talking. There we go. Thank you. We, as you all know, back in December, the Board is aware in our discussion, we talked about HB 1477, which is a law that provides us with this opportunity to implement seed time flexibility.

[06:50:23] I do want to orient our work around the requirements of that legislation. 1477 requires Board of Education, to provide local school boards maximum flexibility to waive existing instructional clock hour requirements by developing alternative instructional time models in accordance with the board's regulations and guidelines relating to instructional time waivers, and directs the board to provide flexibility for school boards to develop programs that provide for acceleration, remediation, and multiple pathways to graduation that permit students to demonstrate competency at different rates.

[06:50:54] I just wanted to make sure that we were all oriented around that being the legislative directive and we use the term seat time flexibility interchangeably as we just mentioned with personalized and company based competency-based learning which is designed to prioritize student outcomes and students advancing at their own pace to engage in innovative experiences I'm gonna let dr. Coons speak for a moment oh it might be maybe that's my problem I'm gonna let dr. Coons speak for a moment about some of the example that we have developed really a library

[06:51:32] of examples from across the state, as we discussed back in December, as well as our stakeholder feedback we've received. I really appreciate the opportunity. I think when we came and chatted about models and examples in December, one of the feedback that you gave us was what is happening in the field in Virginia.

[06:51:52] So we can't go through all of these today, nor do we want to, because we may have a very brief amount of time left for the day. So really encourage you to click on each one of these links. we have cultivated examples in Virginia of models. So when we think of alternative hours, Hampton City Schools implements a 45-15 model that changes that clock hour and that seat time to provide academy opportunities.

[06:52:18] Hopewell City Schools does intersessions, which allows alternative hours where they go in a balanced calendar approach and have two weeks of intersession where kiddos get innovative courses, maybe not by their fourth grade teacher per se, but it also reinforces those fourth grade literacy and math

skills and students who are struggling come during intersession for that innovative content and have more time and more approach before the end of the year.

[06:52:44] That is a K-12 model in Hopewell. It's not just a school, it's a large scale model. Chesterfield offers high school courses from a high school schedule and fits it into a middle school model and changes the course design. We have flexible learning settings.

[06:53:00] guys have heard from Louisa several times, they actually take their teachers for tomorrow and put them in a different location where they get job-embedded support in a childcare facility for employees, but they get their coursework in the same place. So it's a different flexible learning setting. And then we also have blended learning courses in Virginia Beach, which Dr. Armstrong and I had the opportunity to be at Virginia Beach two weeks ago and see students in this bio fit freshman course actually in a health facility. So they were with community members who are working on workout facilities in the pool, having their

[06:53:39] fitness classes and their biology course was in an off site location inside that fitness facility. So we have a lot of opportunities for flexible learning. And we have the opportunity to start small, but talk about what knowledge works in North Dakota talked about where there are examples within us that we need to network and learn from. So we're really excited that these are the four models that have iterated to this point where we are in front of you today on first read for notice and really excited about the level of feedback and the level of engagement because what we're seeing as we listen to stakeholders that our leaders are excited.

[06:54:17] They are tired of that 150 hours, every kind of kid starts the day at this time, ends the day, and this is how it works. But they are requesting it to be simple and start small. And how do they get the guidance? One of the things they said when we looked at guidance is give us the first 10 steps.

[06:54:35] We need to know what the steps are to get us there. And I think you heard a little bit of that when KnowledgeWorks in North Dakota we're talking about how they iterated the struggles they had. So one of the things you will see in the package for first read is you will see not only the notice, the examples of the notice, but the actual action kit.

[06:54:54] And that came out of our feedback, that opportunity to really get those first 10 steps and how to get our school divisions comfortable with and our principals comfortable with what some things are happening in small spaces to spread across our state.

[06:55:09] And then most importantly, they want a video library. They want a video library of examples so they can sit down with their team, start designing and thinking, looking at what other things are happening. So those are exciting things that we've heard.

[06:55:22] Dr. Northern you asked about what are some of the flexibilities what we've heard is that teacher record and that teacher licensure and how they manage that we've also heard some about assessment grading and reporting and what kinds of flexibilities are already happening in some of those models and how they replicate those and make sure that their teachers are comfortable with that space. And now I'm going to turn it over to Dr. Armstrong to do the technical pieces. Thank you, Dr. Coons. As mentioned, we have provided within the action kit.

[06:55:57] In response to the feedback, we've received a notice form with accompanying annotated examples to guide their implementation of these flexible models in schools. They are included in the

Action Kit, which is a clear, step-by-step, phased-in guide for schools to support the streamlined, student-outcome-centered, logistically-manageable plan.

[06:56:17] I think that's a barrier we see with principals and superintendents, just having this come to life. The video library, the Action Kit, does that for them. So we have examples that I'll just scroll through these very quickly. The notice form, in addition to a lot of the sort of boilerplate demographic information about the school and the setting, requires narratives related to the selection of the seat time flex model, as well as the desired outcomes and rationale for students.

[06:56:46] So you can see this is an example of the narrative section of a notice form with a balanced calendar model, which could apply K through 12. We have another one for a middle school model, which would be a fairly typical situation where an earth science high school credit course is offered at both middle and high school in the same division, but due to the schedules being different, maybe an eight-period day at the middle school, a seven-period at the high school, it will require some flexibility and time.

[06:57:10] And then a high school blended course model, which this is the very same program we just mentioned in Virginia Beach, the BioFit class. We have double-blocked co-taught classes that blend content sensibly between PE and biology, for example, in the Virginia Beach model that we saw.

[06:57:28] The notice form does include assurances. Those assurances are going to include reporting attendance, communication with families, and also the requirement to provide support to special populations. So that is included within the notice form. And then the action kit, and I can't get the link up now, but hopefully you've had a chance to take a look at that.

[06:57:48] proud of the work that we've done to create this action kit draft that you'll find linked there at the top of the slide. The action kit is a robust resource for schools to thoughtfully plan and orient their seat time flexibility model and as you walk through that document you'll see we have background, we have links to the video libraries, we have the notice forms, a lot of very practical deep information to guide schools and school divisions and implementation. So we are excited to continue this iterative and responsive work and further flesh out the action kit based on the experiences that we're going to hear about in our schools and we will continue our work to disseminate these models statewide and

[06:58:24] we're here to answer any questions yeah I think one other thing we want to say about the action kit as those challenges arise that KnowledgeWorks and North Dakota talked about one of the things we heard in Virginia Beach is can you give us some transportation options can you give us some things and so as we hear about those we'll continue to build out resources both from Virginia and from

[06:58:47] international models, such as not the things that North Dakota and knowledge works that allows this action kit and the appendices of the action kit become iterative and supportive as our schools evolve and start small and scale what they're trying to do. I also think it's important to note that several school leaders have told us this allows us to scale. A lot of the things we're doing, we've started small and we've stayed small. The opportunity of House Bill 1477 now allows us to scale into larger opportunities so really excited about this work so um just as a comment you know one of the things

[06:59:24] as i thought through this whole process this is really a very unique opportunity for our school divisions to learn from each other and how you know each individual school division that is currently using some type of model as you guys have talked about earlier in the presentation you know sort of to

have that blackboard type resource that says here in Virginia Beach we do x y and z here in Chesapeake we do ABC and and these are the ways in which we handle these

[07:00:03] obstacles and so I would just really encourage us to use some opportunities within this particular option to be able to allow the school divisions to have easier communication with each other on how to best just exercise all opportunities within these models that we have available so i really do appreciate this work so thank you all any comments here dr northern i really like their

[07:00:39] idea of having some type of reporting mechanism whether that be you know general assembly whether it'd be you know partnering with the local Virginia University to give us feedback and evaluate the program because I'm few I think that we need to learn from it and that would be another way that the districts could learn from one another if we actually had some kind of evaluative component to it to share those ideas and also to inform the program as it moves forward what's working what's not what we could strengthen if there is nothing else we're going to take a five minute break and then come back to circle back to item C

[07:01:19] with a presentation along with Dr. Wallace. Take it away. Thank you Madam

[07:10:48] President and board members just waiting for our presentation to appear and that when it does Dr. Wallace and I are going to provide you with an update on the agency's ongoing efforts to provide extensive support to Virginia school divisions and their implementation of the approved school performance and support framework. As the board intended the school performance support framework is intentional in its provision of support to divisions across all dimensions of the framework and its implementation.

[07:11:21] Since its approval, the VDOE team, both in the Office of Accountability and elsewhere in the agency, has provided constant technical assistance, organized on-demand trainings for unique stakeholder groups, responsive to specific questions, and added additional resources in response to the needs of schools and school divisions.

[07:11:40] As the Board knows, the VDOE launched the School Performance Support Framework Resource Hub in November, where anyone, principal, teacher, superintendent, parent, or citizen can find not only the technical details of the framework and transparent data analysis tools, but also important resources geared toward addressing common questions around support for targeted populations, high school readiness, and clear materials for parents to support their child at home.

[07:12:04] The Resource Hub continues to grow as we engage with schools and stakeholders across the state, And you can find regularly updated information on office hours at the Resource Hub Toolkit page, as noted, here we go, on the slide that I know you all have in front of you, right there, circled in red.

[07:12:25] So every week we will update, we have been updating that with the statistics on our office hours and the participation rates. That engagement with schools and stakeholders represents hundreds of hours of in-person trainings, question and answer periods, and technical assistance sessions across the state since last fall.

[07:12:42] Highlights include weekly office hours, which attracted 102 participants from 68 school divisions at our February 5th session, 16 regional superintendent trainings, 12 trainings for division data and testing leaders, and nine trainings for specialized organizations such as VAS, VASSP, VAESP, and BACTI.

[07:13:02] We are also offering dedicated training for divisions on requests, 14 of which have already taken place. And just last week, we scheduled a training for a division on the request of the superintendent to include the local school board to provide a detailed overview of the framework. In addition to the trainings noted here, our team answers individual questions and takes calls every single day in order to provide our schools with the information they need to support the work of the schools in their divisions.

[07:13:27] I want to specifically thank our accountability team and our data team who have collaborated to provide exceptional responsiveness to our schools as mentioned our support goes beyond the data and calculations and targets non-academic barriers that we know affect student performance and we are excited to follow last year's successful attendance webinar and symposium series with this year's program bright spots and bold solutions which will be led by the office of behavioral health and wellness Virginia has been noted nationally for our work to move the needle in reducing chronic absenteeism in the past two years and And this year's attendance series was designed based on feedback from our divisions about

[07:14:04] what they still want to learn more about to improve attendance in their communities. Next month's series will focus on attendance specialists, transportation, mental health, and parental involvement, and will feature guests from divisions sharing best practices that are showing results to lead to dialogue.

[07:14:19] The webinar series will culminate in the VDOE Attendance Symposium here in Richmond, which is being finalized now for location and date. Before I hand it over to Dr. Wallace and provide the Board more information about supports, Dr. Coons, I believe you have a few comments you'd like to make.

[07:14:36] I'm just really proud of the team and all the work they have done to be shoulder-to-shoulder with our school divisions. As Dr. Armstrong mentioned, the volume and support of our two-person accountability team to provide that level of support and the ongoing support that now we are partnering with school superintendents to support their boards and their board transition in this space.

[07:14:59] I also just am incredibly grateful for this attendance work. I think we are featuring three to four school divisions in each one. We talked about the networking and the sharing. This is another example where our school divisions who are leading the way are sharing with other school divisions to support the growth and spread of practices.

[07:15:20] And Dr. Wallace is going to talk about four literacy networks that we have partnered and our work around ZERN, which continues to expand that shoulder-to-shoulder work in academics. So I'm just really thankful for all the work our teams are doing to support our school divisions in the field and connecting our school divisions together to get resources and supports from each other as well. Good afternoon, President Creasy, board members, and Dr. Coons. I am happy to present

[07:15:56] with Dr. Armstrong today on the supports that we're providing to our schools. First, we have the Comprehensive Literacy Network, and this is a network of nine school divisions that provide support as they are implementing the Virginia Literacy Act. These divisions have selected 43 schools that will receive direct individualized support, which includes weekly support for literacy staff as they implement their adopted HQIM curricula, as well as English literacy walkthrough data collection in practice with the division's established

[07:16:31] walkthrough schedules, an analysis of student work samples with a deep dive into the walkthrough data and student work samples to provide professional learning for schools for the

remainder of the school year. We will begin looking at division and school data and that will drive year two of this initiative, which will then expand with the existing nine divisions to introduce other more divisions into this program next year. Our English Learner Literacy network provides supports to school divisions representing 30 schools and 16 school divisions.

[07:17:09] These divisions applied for grants for their schools to participate in this network based on their school's needs. And this support includes three in-person convenings, followed by coaching sessions and technical assistance to support school leaders with evidence-based reading research and to support literacy teams on the impact of structured literacy with English learners.

[07:17:32] This research will continue for the rest of this year, and they will create plans to execute next year to directly support our English learners to improve instructional growth and graduation rates.

[07:17:52] Next, our Students with Disabilities Network provides support to 30 schools from 17 school divisions. As with the EL Network, school divisions applied for grants to participate, and this includes in-person as well as online convenings, for school divisions to collaborate among each other with a focus on high-quality curriculum, staffing, and scheduling to meet the various needs of our students with disabilities.

[07:18:23] Schools will create an action plan to increase student achievement and growth with students with disabilities. All three of these networks will use a common literacy tool as they do their walkthroughs.

[07:18:41] Lastly, I would like to share the supports around mathematics. We have been providing supports to students and schools with that are using our Zern program through a special program called the Anchor Program. As you know, ZERN is our mathematics tutoring provider through the All-In programming, and these schools, which includes 30 schools from 14 school divisions, are receiving additional coaching, and they are getting monthly meetings with division leaders, bi-weekly meetings with each school leader, and they are doing a deep data analysis to help implement ZERN at a deeper

[07:19:19] level. We have already seen a huge amount of success with our ZERN anchor divisions where we had some concerns at the beginning of the year with these divisions and now they are implementing as model school divisions for ZERN. All of this work is very important to support our schools as we go through the Virginia Literacy Implementation Act and then also as we continue to support programming through our all in tutoring i'd like to shout out our videoe english english learner special education office of school quality and mathematics staff as they are supporting all of

[07:19:57] this work with our schools and divisions thank you dr wallace is there does any board member have a question or comment they walked off no just kidding questions or comments miss holton thank you all for these presentations with the respect with the networks and the zern anchor program you're uh can you tell us how the you said you had more applicants than you could serve

[07:20:37] how were the applicants how what was the decision criteria for who participated is the first question and then the second question is uh do we have a research partner or somebody who's studying outcomes in in the network schools versus the non network schools or others in other words how how are we reaping the lessons from these essentially pilot work because it's not well this this work that's going on that's not at scale how are we reaping the the learning lessons that we can then take to scale dr coons i'm going to answer the research piece and then i'm going to

[07:21:16] to let Dr. Wallace talk about how her team worked to select schools. We have research partners for all of the literacy work that is funded by the CLSD and requires a third party evaluation. And then with ZERN, we have a third party evaluation that is going to evaluate impact. So in everything that Dr. Wallace presented, there is an outside entity doing evaluation work. The literacy networks probably are one to three to five years, given that our CLSD grant is five years long, ZERN is going to do an evaluation at the end of this year. In regard to the selection process, I'll start

[07:21:54] with ZERN. So ZERN school divisions were selected at the end of last school year based on the needs of the school division, and so we kind of handpicked those divisions, and we also looked at divisions that had high needs that needed those supports, the extra supports for implementation of the program. And so we looked at our ZERM data as well as the school needs, whether they were ATSI, CSI, that type of status that went with the school at that time. The Comprehensive Literacy Network, which is the nine school

[07:22:31] divisions, those school divisions, again, were kind of hand-selected after we looked at school data. We looked at ATSI, CSI, and TSI school data for our elementary schools, as well as once the data was released in the fall with the new support system, we used that data. And those schools that would have fallen under needs intensive supports were also kind of targeted for those divisions.

[07:22:56] We did reach out to divisions and ask them to participate. And so, you know, that's how they got into the network. And then next year, we will expand that network so that we'll have regional supports all across the state. And the nine that we have this year are going to be used as model divisions. So we'll use the data from this year to kind of drive next year's efforts. For the CLSD grants, that includes the English Learner Network and the Students with Disabilities Networks. Those applications came in by divisions. They applied for each school that they wanted to. So they could

[07:23:30] have applied for more than one network. We selected them based on a rubric that included their current status as well as their projections of what they wanted out of the grant and what they wanted out of the network so there was an application review process. So if a school division applied for a school to be in both the EL network and the SPED network, we looked at their data and we decided which network would best suit them and so therefore they weren't duplicative efforts in a school and more school divisions and schools could be served. And so where you see the the

[07:24:05] count of schools, that would be a duplicative count in both of those. You wouldn't add those two numbers together for the total number because some of them may have applied for both of the networks. And so they got priority points again if they were ATSI or CSI or needs intensive supports identified schools. And so we're working with our neediest schools and what their needs are specifically around students with disabilities and English learner data. You're welcome.

[07:24:37] Anything else? Thank you. Thank you. And we are moving to item D. Will connected overdose parent notification guidelines? Oh, we're more than happy to.

[07:25:02] I'd be happy to do that. Thank you, Madam President and Board members. I would like to provide an overview of the guidelines for school connected overdose response and parental notification policies today for your consideration on first and final review.

[07:25:18] I will provide background and context to this item, including an overview of essential policy and legislation, a review of the extensive stakeholder engagement in both the development of and

feedback to the proposed guidelines, and a description of the key components of the proposed guidelines.

[07:25:35] The guidelines before you today are a result of several cascading policy and legislative priorities that began with the Governor's 2022 introduction of the RightHelp RightNow plan to improve Virginia's behavioral health care system through expansion of access to quality care, in coordination with health care, law enforcement, and mental health organizations and agencies. In 2023, as a result of a large-scale school-connected overdose, the governor issued Executive Order 28, requiring notification to all parents in the school division within 24 hours of a school-connected overdose, and outlining collaboration between school divisions

[07:26:10] and law enforcement. EO 28 directed the VDOE to provide guidance to school divisions with additional detail and resources to implement 24-hour notification. This guidance was provided to school divisions in February of 2024. Finally, the governor signed into law SB 498 in 2024, which required the Board of Education to create the guidelines that are before you today for consideration.

[07:26:34] This law requires that the board establish guidelines, and as you see before in the slide, this is the text from SB 498, which is now that section of the code which requires the board to establish guidelines to include a model action plan detailing agency and law enforcement communications as well as criteria to ensure sensitivity to privacy concerns of affected individuals.

[07:26:57] The VDOE has undertaken extensive input and feedback gathering with both key stakeholders and the public in the development of the guidelines including three town hall listening sessions. In June, agency staff began drafting the guidelines with the input of the Department of Criminal Justice Services, Department of Behavioral Health and Developmental Services, the Virginia Department of Health, as well as counseling and nursing leads from 10 school divisions representing variety in geography and enrollment from across the Commonwealth. In November, key secretariats including education, health and human services and public safety and homeland security provided input to the

[07:27:33] guidelines and in December a school counselor focus group and school nurse focus group were convened to provide input prior to an initial listen and learn session in December. The guidelines were posted to the VDOE web page and included in the VDOE newsletter at the first of the year.

[07:27:49] Three town hall listening sessions were held in January that featured feedback from parents and school staff, both in writing and through verbal feedback during the virtual listening sessions. The feedback was valuable and will inform implementation, though only minor, non-substantial changes were made to the draft document based on the feedback received.

[07:28:08] This table includes the guideline component, associated feedback, and the response from the agency. As you will see in the guidelines draft that is included in your materials, content is organized to include an introduction, terminology section, information detail and clear expectations for administration of the parent notification within 24 hours of the school-connected overdose, model action plans for both response to the school-connected overdose and supportive return to school following an overdose, reporting collaboration requirements between school divisions, law enforcement, and the VDOE, and appendices that include sample

[07:28:48] communications, a sample website template, and a curated pre-populated list of resources to support school divisions and implementation. Upon approval, the agency will immediately shift in implementation and related support to school divisions to include data collection systems, collaboration

with DCGS, technical assistance, and training in preparation for the 2025-2026 school year and I am happy to take any questions at this time. Are there any questions? Dr. Northern?

[07:29:22] I'm just wondering because I'm I've got some educator friends who work in some places where they're experiencing this unfortunately um and use in the guidelines clearly say confirmed but sometimes obviously it takes a long time for an event to get confirmed and when you said it you know it just it doesn't takes a while right right are they are they supposed to issue a um just a medical emergency notification to parents when the overdose has not been confirmed yet? Or is that up to them? I'm not sure find state that we obviously

[07:29:58] encourage notification upon confirmation. But the spirit of this is really to ensure student safety. So the time it may take to confirm with medical and law enforcement really could be a window of time where parents could be communicating with their kids, getting more awareness about something. So the language you'll see is more about suspected so if a principal of a staff member has knowledge of suspected overdose then they would be expected and administer that notification that confirmation would be ideal but we know that can take time one example I've talked about as I've had discussions around this as a principal and a superintendent if you were to see a

[07:30:37] bunch of you know ambulances in front of a school and envision where I work we would send a notification to families because we know that would raise just some concern on their behalf. If a student had a weapon, you would send out a notification about that. I mean, there's a lot of process in between, but making that awareness clear at the very beginning, I think, and the timing is important. So we're encouraging our school divisions to get confirmation, but also to make a notification when it's suspected. The notification doesn't have to be specific, saying it can just be we've had a suspected medical emergency or whatever, because Sometimes they don't want to say suspected when they're not.

[07:31:14] Right, and the template language that's including the guidelines really captures what you're referencing. Yes, ma'am. Ms. Halton.

[07:31:36] Yes, ma'am. There is legislation. It has been neither signed nor vetoed by the governor. So as far as our work today is concerned, we're acting based on the legislation from 2024, which orders to create the guidelines.

[07:31:56] And, of course, if that legislation is signed into law by the governor, I would assume we would need to revisit that and re-examine our guidelines. And right now, there are consistencies, there are areas where it does diverge.

[07:32:15] We haven't really done a deep analysis on that, but again, if that were to come to fruition, I know the board would need to revisit this. Ms. Holton, to help you with that question, having worked pretty significantly on that legislation, there's not much difference here.

[07:32:53] It does. specifically speak to that in the guidelines document and have received assurances, I believe it's gone through review even with OAG to make sure that this complies with FERPA and that student privacy is protected appropriately.

[07:33:12] Other questions? Ms. McPherson. How the funding models work with the barriers, like the apprenticeship, you know, I mean these students are having to go from one place to the other and what provisions we've made things like that on the job training programs and certificate and whether we're

bearing any but we can we can get it we'll discuss that more at the end the next deck here oh okay okay thank you and

[07:33:50] you're doing the next one too yes ma'am settled in here yeah uh item f miss mcpherson this is what you've been waiting for our uh presentational work-based learning and madam president board members i am excited to provide this update to the high quality work-based learning definition experiences and evaluation criteria for the board's consideration for approval on first and final review today.

[07:34:16] I'm sorry, tomorrow is the day of the vote. Yes, I'm sorry. My apologies. There we go. Today's presentation is the culmination of months of board dialogue and deliberation related to work-based learning dating back to 2023.

[07:34:36] I remember this distinctly because the first presentation I gave to the board after coming to the agency, I was extremely nervous, and the board's desire to strengthen the Commonwealth's work-based learning guidelines in order to move forward with thoughtful integration of work-based learning into the state's accountability system. I will provide the board with context and background, an overview of our stakeholder engagement, and the proposed definition, experiences, and evaluation criteria for high-quality work-based learning. Dakota Virginia speaks to the board's responsibility to define high-quality work-based learning. The current definition, the status quo definition used for this purpose, is that high-quality work-based learning consists of school-coordinated workplace

[07:35:15] experiences related to students' career goals and/or interests integrated with instruction related to the core technical competencies of the CTE course and performed in partnership with local businesses. The VDOE currently identifies 12 experiences as high-quality work-based learning.

[07:35:32] As we work to provide the Board with a revised and improved definition, high-quality work-based learning experiences align with meaningful student outcomes and evaluation criteria to guide divisions in the establishment of high-quality work-based learning. The VDOE has collected extensive feedback that has been integrated into the edits as the work-based learning materials have iterated.

[07:35:51] The Board was presented with draft high-quality work-based learning definitions and experiences at the December work session. In the meantime, national and Virginia stakeholders have provided feedback to inform the development and revisions of the high-quality work-based learning guidelines.

[07:36:06] Feedback gathering sessions have been held across the Commonwealth with various key stakeholder groups, including workforce, business, industry, post-secondary and K-12 partners. VDOE engage with all the stakeholders you see there on the slide, which includes many from various agencies, including the Virginia Workforce Development Board, groups of superintendents from certain regions, our Virginia Works partners, the Virginia Office of Education Economics, the list goes on, but you can see that on the slide. As well as the Governor's Student Advisory, which actually was one of my favorite groups to interact with, students from across the state who also were able to give some feedback on this as well.

[07:36:45] The proposed definition of high-quality work-based learning is a school-coordinated experience within the workforce that includes sustained or intensive engagement with industry professionals in high-demand fields in which students apply coursework learning to a real-world setting

while at the same time building critical thinking, collaboration, communication, creative thinking, and citizenship 5C skills.

[07:37:08] Students practice their technical skills and durable skills on a sustained basis, and these experiences accelerate learning toward the goal of earning a National Certificate of Completion, an industry-recognized credential, and/or attain post-secondary credit, and receive feedback and guidance through mentoring and supervision from industry professionals.

[07:37:25] This definition captures the key characteristics of high-quality work-based learning noted by stakeholders, including sustained and intensive engagement with professionals, high-demand fields, attention to the five C's, earning of credentials and/or post-secondary credit, and the critical mentoring, feedback, and guidance by industry professionals.

[07:37:44] The high-quality work-based learning experiences that are proposed include registered apprenticeship, internship, clinical experiences, and school-based enterprise entrepreneurship. These experiences have been identified based on CTE completer data, stakeholder feedback, and the need to provide maximum flexibility to school divisions while still ensuring meaningful, high-quality experiences to students that will result in measurable outcomes prior to graduation.

[07:38:10] Apprenticeship includes both registered and youth registered apprenticeship. Internships include immersion supervised agricultural experiences, as well as supervised work training programs such as Project SEARCH and the Wilson Rehabilitation Center Post-Secondary Rehabilitation Transition program.

[07:38:26] And clinical experiences will focus on health and medical sciences, school-based enterprise and entrepreneurship, engage students in a supervised experience planning and managing their own business venture. School-based enterprise also provides flexibility to divisions that may have limited access to business and industry partners to provide some of those other experiences.

[07:38:45] We noted that in the feedback as recent as yesterday when we spoke to our rural superintendents. The criteria for evaluation aligns with the proposed definition and reflects the key characteristics of a high-quality work-based learning experience. As you can see, the checklist retains criteria for graduation requirements and for 3E readiness as we have discussed continuing to count the existing 12 high-quality work-based learning experiences for graduation requirements while we propose including the 3E readiness work-based learning experiences, apprenticeship, internship, clinical, school-based enterprise, for inclusion in our accountability system.

[07:39:19] Ultimately, we recommend to the Board that Virginia's high-quality work-based learning experiences merge into those 3E readiness experiences for both graduation requirements and accountability eventually, and we recommend conversation on the timing of that phase in with the board in the coming months.

[07:39:36] As we consider shifting immediately into implementation upon board approval, we are already working to better leverage our CTE workflow to support school divisions, business workforce and post-secondary partners with training, technical assistance and boots on the ground support to galvanize connections and communities to move this work forward on behalf of students in the workforce. We hope the Board will consider integration of work-based learning into the school performance and support

framework in March, as well as consider the timeline for the shift from graduation requirement work-based learning to the new higher standard of 3E work-based learning for students. And

[07:40:10] with that, I'm happy to take any questions. Are there any questions? Ms. Hulton? Thank you, Dr. Armstrong. First question, again, I think there's legislation working its way through the general assembly if it is signed by the governor is this uh are the are these actions consistent with those legislation or will we have to redo it sorry um they they were before they

[07:40:40] were introduced excellent uh second question uh see we have a letter in the public comment uh from somebody raising a concern that we're not that we've excluded externships we've provided for internships, but apparently we've excluded externships. I don't know what that even is, but what is that right? We're excluding them and what are they received that feedback. And Dr.

[07:41:08] Coons and I have had that conversation as well as reached out to some of our experts in this and populated that in our feedback. An internship is when you are being supervised and doing the work, whereas an externship, and I'm not saying it's not valuable, but for the purposes of our three writing a standard and work-based learning an externship is more of a job shadowing than it is actually doing the work.

[07:41:33] You're there learning from the outside, but you're not being supervised to actually learn to do the work. And we see in the data as well that the externships don't translate to those outcomes the way that an internship and those other experiences do. So we considered it is still a valuable career exploration activity, which we've captured in our career exploration definition, but not meeting that standard of the 3E readiness.

[07:41:58] - Thank you, that helps clarify. And so we're, for 3E readiness, we're requiring, we're authorizing internships, but not externships. - That is correct. - And then my last question is, I'm not, still not clear whether, where are the, what are the differences between our 3E readiness definitions and our graduation definitions?

[07:42:19] - You'll see. - Why, help me again. That's fine to illustrate that in the evaluation criteria, and there are a lot, there are many parallels that are consistent between the graduation requirement, high quality work-based learning, our new 3E, but you'll see here that there were, we have a minimum of 90 hours for 3E readiness, which while lower than what was there before, which is really antiquated and based on the Carnegie 140 hour clock hour requirement, is still higher than most states.

[07:42:48] And we don't require that for the graduation? The graduation, work-based learning, it depends on the experience. Some of them require different numbers of hours, but 140 is kind of consistent among those. The artifact, soon-to-be artifact, graduation requirement. Oh, so the graduation requirements are higher than the 3E?

[07:43:06] Some of them are, yes, yes, which is something we receive feedback from the field. And that 3E is higher than many other states do? Than many states. I won't say every state, but than many states, yes, ma'am. And you know the high demand field is another part of our 3E definition, and we've had some discussion about that as well, and then we're settling on high demand in this.

[07:43:26] The alignment to CTE course is consistent across both, and then it's going from providing opportunities to apply the 5Cs to then completing an assessment that documents your attainment of the 5Cs. It's just a different level of rigor in the definition between the graduation requirement and 3E.

[07:43:44] you're provided an opportunity to earn these things but to get the 3e credit or to make this a work-based learning experience for under 3e you earn that you have that that is earned and then instead of providing the opportunity alone for these mentorships then you have documentation of a structured mentorship with an industry professional in sight so it's really the differences are just that that higher level of rigor and engagement between graduation requirement 3e i appreciate and i apologize for making you go through it again no no worries no i didn't go go through that in detail to begin with so happy to do so I'm sorry dr. northern I was just gonna

[07:44:22] say thank you I found this this chart very helpful I think when I was looking at last time I couldn't get it straight in my mind and this is really cohesive and shows nicely and I really do feel like what you guys have sketched out here with the bullets are high quality worst based learning experiences and I just ties into the earlier conversation of how important it will be for us to have models and proof points so that kids get enough time right to do a registered apprenticeship and I mean these things all take time and they're going to be competing and I would suggest that me the Christo Rey model is a really good model for us to kind of learn from I'm actually doing an

[07:45:01] evaluation of it in my day job and trying to figure out like how do they how do they make the time for kids to be in these corporate workplaces and still you know check all the boxes on the academics so there are some models we could learn from Thank you, Dr. Norther. And I'll mention, too, I think seat time flexibility is really the oil that's going to make this portfolio run, whether it's dual enrollment, work-based learning, that's a catalyst that's going to make all that happen more effectively.

[07:45:30] Thank you, Dr. Armstrong. Thank you all. I think that's it. Okay, so that takes us to item G. So, Mr. Hansen, that's you. We will now go into a closed session, which we hope to keep brief. Mr. Hansen, would you make your motion?

[07:46:02] move that the virginia board of education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes consultation with legal counsel employed by or retained by a public body regarding specific legal matters requiring their provision of legal advice by such counsel pursuant to section 2.2-3711 a8 of the code of virginia and the legal counsel to the virginia's board of education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting

[07:46:31] Is there a second? All those in favor respond. Dr. Northern, Ms. Kilgore, Mr. Hansen, Ms. McPherson, Ms. Holton. Aye. Chair votes aye. We're now in closed session. Thank you.

[07:52:14] Mr. Hansen, can you read our certification to return to open session, please?

[08:00:25] We convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia requires that the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard, discussed, or considered.

[08:00:54] Any member who believes there is a departure from these requirements shall show a state prior to the vote indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Dr. Northern, Ms. Kilgore.

[08:01:12] - Aye. - Ms. McPherson. - Aye. - Ms. Holton, chair votes aye. So that brings us out of closed session officially. And do you have any comments for tomorrow? I mean for today, not tomorrow, it's not tomorrow yet.

[08:01:28] Okay, so I will take a motion to adjourn our work session this afternoon. All those in favor, we're adjourned.

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